

Virasat Bhi, Vikas Bhi



Construction of the Grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya

Transformation of Kashi Vishwanath Dham, Mahakal Mahalok and Kedarnath Dham

12

vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-Kalyan ke



CBC 44.101/13/10006/2627

AT G7, MODI FLAGS HORMUZ SAFETY CONCERNS

Strait talk on seafarers' safety

If anyone attacks India, we will defend it: Trump

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

EVIAN-LES-BAINS (FRANCE): In a meeting with the U.S. President Donald Trump Prime Minister Narendra Modi raised concerns over the safety of Indian seafarers operating in the Strait of Hormuz.

During the brief interaction on the sidelines of G7 Summit here, PM Modi also mentioned stability in West Asia. "Many Indian seafarers are in Strait of Hormuz, their safety is of utmost importance," PM Modi told President Trump at a bilateral meet while bringing up the issue of safety of Indian seafarers, who make up 10 per cent of global seafarers, and stressed its importance.

PM Modi told Trump that the deal with Iran offers "new hope for peace and stability" in West Asia. "And I am confident that this will lead to a longstanding peace in the region," the prime minister said.



PEOPLE SAY HE IS SUCH A NICE MAN. I SAID HE'S VERY VERY TOUGH. HE'S A TOUGH NEGOTIATOR, AND HE LOVES THE INDIAN PEOPLE, BUT HE ALSO LOVES THE US: TRUMP

CLOSER LOOK

- » Many Indian seafarers are in Strait of Hormuz, their safety is of utmost importance: PM Modi to Trump
- » 'Deal with Iran offers 'new hope for peace and stability' in West Asia'
- » The two leaders focused on taking steps to repair bilateral ties that witnessed severe strain over the past year
- » Trump, describing New Delhi as a trusted partner, said the US will defend India if anyone attacks it

Modi holds talks with Zelenskyy

EVIAN-LES-BAINS (FRANCE): India will "always be" on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Wednesday after holding talks with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. Modi met Zelenskyy on the sidelines of the G7 summit in the French commune of Evian-les-Bains. "Met President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Evian. In recent times, India and Ukraine have been engaging extensively. This has been reflected in different areas of our cooperation," Modi said in a post on X. "Our talks today were about reviewing different aspects of our cooperation. We both agree that trade ties need to be restored to what they were in the pre-war time. Also reiterated that India will always be on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else," he said. See P4

Are regional parties FACING A REVOLT?



After Trinamool turmoil, SP and Shiv Sena (UBT) face murmurs of dissent

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW/ MUMBAI: After the recent rebellion in Trinamool Congress, it appears that regional parties are facing fresh trouble of dis-sidence and split with hints of their MPs breaking away from their parties. Two such parties said to be facing the prospects of rebellion are Samajwadi Party in UP and Shiv Sena (UBT) in Maharashtra.

Signs of an intensified political battle ahead of the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections emerged this week after two senior ministers in the Yogi Adityanath government claimed that the Samajwadi Party (SP) was headed for an internal split, prompting SP chief Akhilesh Yadav to accuse the BJP of using fear and inducements to engineer defections.

A day after Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya claimed that "25 to 26" Samajwadi Party MPs were ready to defect, Uttar Pradesh Cabinet minister and Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief Om Prakash Rajbhar asserted that a major split in the opposition party was imminent.

Maurya said the BJP was

RS battle

RANCHI: All preparations have been completed to conduct the election to two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand on Thursday, for which three candidates are in the fray, an official said.

The opposition BJP-led NDA decided to support an Independent candidate, despite lacking the required number of MLAs in the assembly.

Three candidates – JMM's Baidyanath Ram, Congress's Pranav Jha and BJP-backed Independent nominee Parimal Nathwani – are contesting the polls for the two seats.

The voting will take place between 9 am and 4 pm at a polling station set up within the Jharkhand Assembly premises. See P5

not attempting to poach MPs from the SP, but claimed they would leave the party on their own before the 2027 Assembly elections.

"Twenty-five to twenty-six Samajwadi Party MPs are ready to split. Continued on P4

India's education system an extortion machine, rejection system

Rahul Gandhi

In today's paper

CITY

NEET ASPIRANT FOUND DEAD 2

NATION

PM TO GIVE RS 2.4K CRORE 5

EDIT

BATTLE FOR THE SENA 7

INTERNATIONAL

G7 FOCUSES ON AI 8

BUSINESS

INDIA, EU TO SIGN FTA BY END OF 2026 9

SPORT

MESSI MAKES HISTORY 10

'NOW BIBI HAS TO BE MORE RESPONSIBLE WITH RESPECT TO LEBANON'

'Crazy': No Israel without me, says Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told President Donald Trump last year that he was the "greatest friend Israel ever had in the White House."

Now, as Trump tries to finalise a deal to end the war with Iran, he's unloading on Netanyahu with rhetoric that no other American leader has dared to use publicly.

He claimed credit for Israel's existence — "without me, there would be no Israel" — and cursed his judgment in interviews. He even described him as "crazy."



Netanyahu's tenure as prime minister spans four US presidents, and he's frustrated all of them at one point or another. But none has voiced that as openly as Trump, who started the conflict in tandem with Netanyahu.

A BITTER TURN

- » The tension comes as Trump criticises recent Israeli attacks in Lebanon, which threatened to jeopardise negotiations between Washington and Tehran
- » Trump has been pushing for a deal as he faces political blowback at home, where the war is unpopular and has driven up gasoline prices
- » 'If Netanyahu gets in between something Trump really wants, and that's out of this war, he's prepared to use the leverage that he has'

The tension comes as Trump criticises recent Israeli attacks in Lebanon, which threatened to jeopardise negotiations between Washington and Tehran. Trump has been pushing for a deal as he faces political blowback at home,

where the war is unpopular and has driven up gasoline prices.

"If Netanyahu gets in between something Trump really wants, and that's out of this war, he's prepared to use the leverage that he has," said Continued on P4

WATER SALUTE



An Acom Cargo aircraft receives a ceremonial water cannon salute after landing with the first cargo flight at Noida International Airport, in Jewar, Uttar Pradesh PTI

AROUND 15 LAKH VEHICLES IN 45 DAYS; COPS DEPLOY 5-POINT PLAN

Hill station rush: Wheels, waves & a plan

BHANU P LOHUMI

SHIMLA: Around 15 lakh vehicles entered Shimla between May 1 and June 15, with police adopting a five-point strategy to tackle the summer tourist rush.

The traffic management measures include deployment of additional force, strict surveillance, mapping alternative routes and encouraging public transport, a senior police official said.

As schools close for summer holidays, tourists are making a bee-line for destinations across Himachal Pradesh. The heavy influx has sparked frequent traffic jams along highways and link roads.

According to hoteliers, average occupancy at tourist accommodations across Himachal Pradesh last week stood at 60-70 per cent during weekdays, rising to 80-90 per cent on the weekends.

"Over 15 lakh vehicles have



» 'THREE CRANES HAVE BEEN STATIONED IN DIFFERENT SECTORS TO SWIFTLY HANDLE SUCH SITUATIONS'

entered Shimla in the past 45 days and police have come up with a five-point strategy to deal with the rush," Superintendent of Police Gaurav Singh said.

He said managing the tourist influx is not a problem if internal bottlenecks are addressed.

The traffic strategy involves deployment of additional force, interceptor vehicles and bike-borne personnel for traffic regulation, monitoring by gazetted officers, use of alternative roads, and encouraging public transport and awareness.

THE STRATEGY

- » The traffic strategy involves deployment of additional force, interceptor vehicles and bike-borne personnel for traffic regulation, monitoring by gazetted officers, use of alternative roads, and encouraging public transport and awareness'
- » 'Malfunctioning heavy vehicles such as buses or trucks on the Cart Road, the lifeline of the hill town, are a major issue as they often cause long traffic jams'

He said malfunctioning heavy vehicles such as buses or trucks on the Cart Road, the lifeline of the hill town, are a major issue as they often cause long traffic jams. Bringing in a crane on a single-lane road to tow away an impaired vehicle is a time-consuming process, Singh said. Continued on P4

Telegram takes temporary ban to court

Government cites misuse of platform; Telegram calls curbs illegal

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Telegram approached the Delhi High Court on Wednesday with its plea against the Centre's order temporarily restricting access to the messaging app ahead of the June 21 NEET-UG 2026 re-examination.

A vacation bench of Justice Tejas Karia asked the Centre to file its reply on Telegram's plea. Telegram's counsel claimed the curbs were illegal, but Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta

LAKHS OF STUDENTS HAVE BEEN STUDYING ON TELEGRAM FOR YEARS... HOW DOES SNATCHING THAT FACILITY BECOME THE SOLUTION TO PAPER LEAKS? — RAHUL GANDHI

defended the government action, saying the platform was being misused and he would reveal "something shocking" as the court adjourned the hear-

ing to Thursday and issued notice to the Centre.

During the hearing, Telegram's counsel questioned the legality of the government order blocking the platform. He said that over 150 million users had been affected by the Centre's action on Tuesday.

SG Mehta sought an adjournment, saying that he had not put several things on record. He told the court that the platform was being misused.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology

(MeitY), acting on recommendations of the National Testing Agency (NTA), issued a direction under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, restricting access to the Telegram platform in India till June 22, covering the day of the NEET (UG) 2026 re-examination and its immediate aftermath. A separate direction requires Telegram to disable in India the message-editing feature for already-posted messages till June 30, 2026, addressing Continued on P4

NSE files for ₹30K-cr IPO

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) on Wednesday filed preliminary papers with markets regulator Sebi for its much-awaited IPO, estimated at around Rs 30,000 crore, a share sale that is poised to become the largest public issue in Indian stock market history.

The filing marks a major milestone for NSE, whose listing plans had been stalled for nearly a decade due to regulatory hurdles, including the co-location controversy.

The public issue will be entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of 14.89 crore shares with existing shareholders collectively divesting nearly 6 per cent of the exchange's stake, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP).

Among the top-selling shareholders, State Bank of India will offload up to 2.48 crore shares, followed by MS Strategic (Mauritius) Limited with 1.60 crore shares.

Meanwhile, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), the single largest shareholder in NSE, holding a 10.72 per cent stake, will not offload any shares. See P9

Goodbye Indo-Pacific?

WASHINGTON: The US has restored the name of the US Indo-Pacific Command to the US Pacific Command, reversing an eight-year-old decision. The US Department of Defence announced the decision on Tuesday, saying that the designation honours the Command's deep historical roots, established in 1947 by then-President Harry Truman.

Also, the "area of responsibility" map on the Pacific Command website, which depicts an inaccurate picture of India's borders, has triggered political reactions in the country. The map in question excludes Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and Aksai Chin from India.

The website section where the inaccurate map is placed contains a disclosure that the concerned web page was last updated in March. See P8

Strategic oil reserves cover 10 days: Report

NEW DELHI: India's current strategic petroleum reserves are equivalent to just about 9-10 days of the country's net crude imports, far below other major import-dependent countries, a new report revealed on Wednesday.

The report released by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) said other countries that rely heavily on crude imports – such as Japan and South Korea – maintain reserves sufficient for over 200 days.

The report, "How Secure is India's Energy Future? Assessing Accessibility, Reliability, and Affordability," also noted that over 85 per cent of India's crude oil imports come from just six countries, including Russia and key West Asian suppliers, limiting flexibility supply shocks.

Hemant Malliya, fellow at the CEEW, said, "Disruptions in crude oil, LNG, LPG, coal, or key shipping routes can quickly affect cooking costs, transport fuel prices, fertiliser subsidies, industrial competitiveness, and inflation." See P9

FREIGHT SERVICES ADD NEW DIMENSION TO OPS

First cargo aircraft lands at Noida International Airport

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Noida International Airport (NIA) on Wednesday achieved another milestone with the commencement of dedicated cargo operations, just two days after the launch of commercial passenger services. A Boeing 737-800F freighter from Chennai became the first cargo aircraft to land at the airport's newly operational cargo terminal.

The aircraft touched down at 7.13 am carrying around 20 tonnes of mixed freight, including auto components, mobile phones and perishable goods. Airport authorities welcomed the flight with a ceremonial water-cannon salute. After unloading cargo, the aircraft departed for Chennai at around 12.15 pm carrying shipments from industrial units in the Noida region, including automobile and engineering components.

Officials said the launch of cargo services is expected to significantly strengthen the logistics ecosystem of western Uttar Pradesh and the National Capital Region. The airport's



Ground staff unload cargo from the first cargo flight to arrive at Noida International Airport, in Jewar, Uttar Pradesh, on Wednesday

operations are being managed by Acom Holdings, whose chairman and managing director Deepak Parsuraman described the inaugural Chennai-Noida-Chennai freighter service as a significant step for India's growing air cargo sector. He said the flight completed the journey between Chennai and Noida in 2 hours and 27 minutes.

The cargo terminal has been developed by Air India SATS Airport Services Pvt Ltd (AISATS) over 87 acres. The facility includes a 30-acre inte-

grated cargo terminal along with a 57-acre logistics and warehousing zone. It has an annual handling capacity of 2.55 lakh tonnes of cargo.

According to airport officials, the terminal has already started processing consignments such as garments, hand-icrafts, mobile phones and automobile parts. In the past two days, nearly four tonnes of litchis from Pathankot were also routed through the airport for onward transportation to cities including Mumbai, Hyderabad and Bengaluru.

HIGHLIGHTS

» Aircraft touched down at 7.13 am carrying around 20 tonnes of mixed freight, including auto components, perishable goods and phones

» After unloading cargo, the aircraft departed for Chennai at around 12.15 pm carrying shipments from industrial units in the Noida region

new facility would also help ease pressure on Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport. NIAL nodal officer Shailendra Bhatia said Noida's position as a major manufacturing hub for electronics, IT products and mobile devices would generate substantial cargo traffic. To facilitate seamless movement, separate access routes have been created for passenger and freight vehicles.

The new facility, he said, would help businesses access domestic and international markets more quickly while improving supply-chain efficiency.

Airport authorities believe the terminal's location near industrial sectors of YEIDA will allow exporters to move goods from factories to aircraft within a short time. Future rail links connecting the facility to the Delhi-Howrah and Delhi-Mumbai railway corridors, along with access to the Eastern and Western Dedicated Freight Corridors, are expected to transform the airport into a multimodal logistics hub integrating road, rail and air transportation.

Two in cop net for shooting man dead in Dayalpur area

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two men were arrested for killing a 40-year-old man who was shot dead in northeast Delhi's Dayalpur area earlier this week, police said on Wednesday.

Ayan (21), a resident of Chand Bagh, and Imran (20), a resident of Khajuri Khas, were arrested on Tuesday, they said.

A scooter allegedly used in the crime was seized from their possession, and was later found to have been stolen from the Noor-e-Elahi area, police said.

According to police, the assailants gunned down Rashid on Monday in Dayalpur, following which he was rushed to a hospital, where doctors



declared him dead.

A purported video of the incident that surfaced after the killing showed three men arriving on a scooter, two of them wearing helmets. The assailants were seen getting off the vehicle, firing at the victim, and fleeing the scene.

The police had earlier described Rashid as a 'bad character' who had been involved

in cases related to extortion, causing grievous hurt, theft and other criminal activities.

Following the killing, dedicated police teams examined CCTV footage, analysed technical and human intelligence inputs, and collected evidence from multiple sources.

The investigation led to the identification and arrest of both on Tuesday, while the third accused remains absconding, police said.

During sustained interrogation, both accused allegedly admitted to their involvement in the killing, the police said.

Officials said efforts were underway to ascertain the role of other persons who may have participated in the crime.

Police, NCB conduct anti-drug search op

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police, in coordination with the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) and other agencies, conducted a joint search and checking operation near Vishwavidyalaya Metro Station and Maurice Nagar in north Delhi as part of an intensified campaign against drug abuse, an officer said on Wednesday.

'People found loitering at sensitive spots were questioned...'

The operation was carried out on Tuesday with the assistance of a canine squad.

"Teams checked kiosks, pan and bidi shops, tea stalls, public gathering points

and secluded corners with the assistance of a trained sniffer dog," a senior police officer said.

People found loitering at sensitive spots were questioned, while local shopkeepers, vendors and residents were approached for information regarding suspected narcotic activity or habitual drug users frequenting the locality, he further informed.

BSES introduces citywide drive to boost rooftop solar adoption

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI:Power distribution company BSES has launched a multi-platform awareness campaign across Delhi to promote rooftop solar adoption and highlight benefits available under the Centre's PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and the Delhi Solar Policy.

As part of the initiative, radio jingles are being aired on leading FM stations, while advertisements have been placed at key Delhi Metro stations to reach a wider audience. BSES is also using its

'The campaign focuses on the financial benefits of rooftop solar, including subsidies under the PM Surya Ghar scheme...'

social media platforms to educate consumers about rooftop solar systems and the incentives available for installation.

The campaign focuses on the financial benefits of rooftop solar, including subsidies

under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, incentives offered by the Delhi government and flexible financing options. Consumers can significantly reduce their electricity bills, with some households potentially achieving zero power bills depending on system size and usage. Surplus electricity can also be exported to the grid through net metering.

BSES said it has facilitated over 13,600 rooftop solar connections with a cumulative installed capacity of nearly 260 MWp across South, West, East and Central Delhi.

Poor response to property regularisation drive prompts MCD to consider reducing charges & awareness camps

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than a month after the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) launched a portal to regularise properties in unauthorised colonies, the civic body is considering a reduction in regularisation charges after receiving only two applications from eligible beneficiaries, officials said on Thursday.

The SWAGAM portal, launched on April 24, enables residents of unauthorised colonies to regularise their properties on an "as is where is" basis after securing ownership

rights under the Centre's Pradhan Mantri Unauthorised Colonies in Delhi Awas Adhikar Yojana (PM-UDAY).

Despite nearly 40,000 PM-UDAY beneficiaries being eligible to proceed with the process, only two applications have been submitted through the portal so far. Officials attributed the poor response largely to the absence of any deadline or penalty for delaying applications. Residents can continue occupying their properties without seeking regularisation, and there is currently no provision for punitive action against those who do not apply.



To boost participation, the MCD is in discussions with the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to reduce regularisation charges, including fees linked to Floor Area Ratio (FAR). Officials said the civic body has also suggested to the Delhi government that a timeline be prescribed for applica-

tions, although any such move would require approval from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).

The Delhi government and the MCD are also planning district-wise awareness camps to help residents understand the process of obtaining ownership rights under PM-UDAY and subsequently applying for regularisation through the SWAGAM portal.

Officials said the MCD has already sent six rounds of messages to around 40,000 PM-UDAY beneficiaries, urging them to secure ownership rights and complete the regu-

larisation process. They added that many residents remain reluctant to incur regularisation costs, perceiving little immediate benefit from doing so. The civic body has also conducted awareness campaigns through auto-tippers operating in unauthorised colonies, using public announcements and jingles to spread information about the scheme. To simplify the process, the MCD has empanelled around 711 architects to assist applicants in preparing and uploading building plans and has put in place facilitation measures to ease documentation and approvals.

Safdarjung Airport comes under CISF security cover

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) on Wednesday formally took over security responsibilities at Safdarjung Airport, bringing the facility under its protection umbrella as the 73rd civil aviation installation secured by the force.

Senior CISF officers, along with representatives of the Airports Authority of India (AAI) and local law enforcement agencies, were present during the handover. The move is part of the Ministry of Home Affairs' broader effort to strengthen and standardise aviation security across the country through a dedicated central security framework.

Spread across 213 acres in



south Delhi, Safdarjung Airport is located in a high-security zone surrounded by key defence and government establishments. The airport plays a crucial role in handling non-scheduled flights, including helicopter operations involving the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, Union ministers, Governors and other

senior dignitaries.

The deployment follows recommendations by security agencies for enhanced protection, citing the airport's strategic importance, proximity to residential areas and exposed runway layout. CISF personnel were inducted in phases under the Internal Security Duty Pattern to ensure uninterrupted airport operations.

A dedicated CISF unit of 136 personnel, headed by a Deputy Commandant, has been tasked with securing the airport. The force will oversee perimeter security, access control, baggage screening systems, surveillance networks and response mechanisms, replacing the earlier arrangement involving Delhi Police and Nagaland Police personnel.

Teen NEET aspirant found dead at home, police rule out foul play

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 17-year-old NEET aspirant allegedly died by suicide at her residence in Palam Colony, with police saying that no evidence of foul play or abetment has emerged during the investigation so far.

According to police, the incident came to light on June 13 when a PCR call was received at Palam Village Police Station regarding a teenage girl who had been brought unconscious to Indira Gandhi Hospital in Dwarka. Doctors declared her brought dead.

During inquest proceedings conducted under Section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), investigators found that the girl had allegedly died by sui-



A suicide note was recovered by cops

cide by hanging herself at her residence.

A police team, along with crime scene experts, visited the spot and carried out a detailed inspection. Statements of family members were recorded

as part of the inquiry. Officials said none of the relatives alleged harassment, foul play or abetment by any individual in connection with the death.

During the examination of the scene, police recovered a notebook containing a handwritten suicide note. The note and the ligature material allegedly used in the incident were seized in accordance with legal procedures. The body was sent for post-mortem examination and later handed over to the family after completion of medico-legal formalities.

Police said no suspicious circumstances have surfaced so far, and the inquiry has not indicated any criminal involvement or evidence suggesting that any person instigated or aided the alleged suicide.

Delhi Police transfers 4,889 personnel in major reshuffle

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has ordered the transfer of 4,889 personnel, including 3,133 constables and 1,756 head constables, as part of a large-scale reshuffle carried out under a newly introduced transfer and posting policy, an official said on Wednesday.

The transfer orders were issued through a software-based system after the personnel completed their prescribed tenure in their respective units, a senior

police officer said.

According to Delhi Police, the exercise involved the movement of personnel between frontline and support units to ensure balanced deployment and operational efficiency across the force.

"Personnel who had completed their tenure in frontline units have been transferred to support units, while those serving in support units have been posted to frontline assignments. MPOST

1 held for killing bus helper during robbery in Shastri Park: Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 19-year-old man was arrested for allegedly stabbing a bus helper to death during a robbery in northeast Delhi's Shastri Park area, police said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Anwar, was arrested after police formed multiple teams and examined CCTV footage from the area, police said.

"The knife used in the crime was recovered from the accused. The victim was carrying around Rs 10,000 in cash at the time of the incident, which is still missing," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Northeast) Rahul Alwal said.

According to the police, the incident took place on the intervening night of June 14 and 15 when Musharraf (25), a resident of Alwar district in Rajasthan who worked as a helper on a private bus in Delhi, was returning home.

The knife used in the crime was recovered from the accused: Police

He was allegedly intercepted by a group of assailants who attempted to rob him. When he resisted, the attackers allegedly stabbed him multiple times before fleeing the spot, police said.

He was later found lying in a pool of blood and was rushed to Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital, where he succumbed to his injuries during treatment.

Musharraf was the sole earning member of his family, police said, adding that he is survived by his parents and sisters, who were financially dependent on him. DCP Alwal said multiple teams are working on the case and the remaining accused involved in the crime will be arrested soon.

FIRST PHASE TO COVER FIVE JJ CLUSTERS

Govt to begin JJ cluster rehabilitation projects

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has constituted an inter-departmental committee to facilitate school admissions and address civic amenities issues for families rehabilitated from three JJ clusters in the Race Course area to the Savda Ghevra Rehabilitation Colony, even as the Centre and the city government have finalised the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Resettlement Policy, 2026.

According to a circular issued by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB), the committee will coordinate with the Directorate of Education, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and other agencies to ensure admission of children from rehabilitated families in nearby government and MCD schools.



It will also function as a nodal mechanism for resolving grievances related to water supply, sewerage, electricity and other civic amenities.

The committee, chaired by a DUSIB Executive Engineer, includes representatives from DUSIB, the Delhi Jal Board, the Directorate of Education, Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) and the MCD. Operating from a camp office at Savda Ghevra, it will receive and address complaints from beneficiary families while

ensuring coordination among stakeholder agencies.

The circular stated that the committee was constituted in compliance with directions issued by the Delhi High Court on June 4. The court had directed authorities to ensure school admissions for children of rehabilitated families and provide assistance in resolving issues related to civic services, warning that any non-compliance would be viewed seriously.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that the Centre and the Delhi government have finalised the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Resettlement Policy, 2026, at a high-level meeting chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

Under the policy, rehabilitation projects for five JJ clusters will be taken up in the first phase.

Delhi to launch month-long child protection drive, schools face POCSO audit: L-G Sandhu

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor (LG) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday directed a comprehensive audit of schools to assess adherence to the provisions and guidelines of the POCSO Act.

Sandhu chaired a meeting to review the implementation status of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act across the capital, along with the Delhi Police, the Women and Child Department and the Department of Education. "Directed a comprehensive audit of schools across Delhi to assess adherence to the provisions and guidelines of the POCSO Act. The education department has also been instructed to enforce strict compliance and initiate firm action against institutions found lacking in implementation," Sandhu said in a post on X.

The L-G directed the Delhi Police to ensure deployment around school premises and

prominent student hubs, particularly during school dispersal hours, to deter any untoward incidents and strengthen public confidence. "Emphasised a zero-tolerance approach towards eve-teasing, harassment and molestation of women and children," he said.

To institutionalise safety at the ground level, the LG directed that every school must have the mandatory dedicated Child Protection Committee that should meet regularly to monitor the environment.

"He further instructed the authorities to observe July as the child protection month and carry out a dedicated, city-wide one-month child protection campaign to create awareness and provide mandatory training to all stakeholders," an official said.

The safety, dignity, and well-being of every student remain non-negotiable, he said.

"We are committed to building a secure, fearless, and protective environment for every child in Delhi," he said.

DDA gears up for citywide Yoga Day celebrations across 29 sites

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will organise large-scale celebrations of the International Day of Yoga at 29 locations across the national capital on June 21, with programmes aimed at promoting health, fitness and overall well-being.

The events will be held at DDA sports complexes, parks and public spaces across the city, encouraging widespread public participation. Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu will lead the main Yoga session at Baansera. DDA Vice Chairman N. Saravana Kumar, senior officials and other dignitaries are also expected to participate.

This year's International Day of Yoga theme, "Yoga for



Healthy Ageing", highlights the role of Yoga in supporting physical, mental and emotional well-being across all age groups while encouraging active and healthy ageing.

Yoga sessions will be organised at several DDA sports facilities, including Siri Fort Sports Complex, Saket Sports Complex, Yamuna Sports Complex, Dwarka Sports Complex and Rohini Sports Complex. Similar programmes will also be

held at prominent green spaces such as Baansera, Swarn Jayanti Park, Coronation Park, Hauz Khas Park and Sanjay Lake Park. The sessions will feature Yoga asanas, pranayama, breathing exercises, meditation and wellness activities under the guidance of trained Yoga instructors deputed by the Ministry of Ayush. Thousands of students, sportspersons and members of local communities are expected to take part in the celebrations.

The DDA said the citywide observance reflects its commitment to promoting healthier lifestyles and creating a fitter, greener Delhi. The authority currently manages 18 sports complexes, four mini sports complexes, three golf courses and more than 730 parks across the Capital.

News at a glance

TWO ARRESTED FOR FAKE OVERSEAS JOB SCAM

NEW DELHI: Cyber Cell has busted a cyber fraud syndicate that allegedly duped job seekers with fake employment offers from reputed Japanese companies, including Toyota and Nippon Steel. Two accused from Bareilly were arrested after a woman reported losing Rs 1.63 lakh. Investigators recovered digital evidence and found the network targeted victims through fake interviews and recruitment scams.

FIRE BREAKS OUT AT RESTAURANT

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out at a takeaway restaurant in Satya Niketan on Wednesday morning, prompting the deployment of multiple fire tenders. The blaze, reported at 6.10 am, was confined to furniture and utensils on the ground floor and was brought under control within 40 minutes.

Cleanliness drives mark 12 years of Modi government

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Ministers, legislators and public representatives across Delhi on Wednesday led cleanliness campaigns in different parts of the Capital to commemorate 12 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's tenure, with the city government pitching the exercise as a mass movement driven by citizen participation.

From Model Town and Najafgarh to Kalkaji and Chandni Chowk, public spaces, parks and religious sites witnessed shramdaan activities involving ministers, MPs,

councillors, sanitation workers and local residents. The drives were organised under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as part of a citywide initiative promoting cleanliness and civic responsibility.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa participated in a cleanliness drive in Model Town alongside local MLA Ashok Goel, councillors and residents.

Stressing the importance of public participation, Sirsa said, "A Clean India is the foundation of a Developed India. The dream of a Clean India can only be realised through collective



responsibility and active public participation."

He also announced that the Delhi government would soon launch a major plantation initiative under which 70

lakh saplings would be planted across the city. Citizens would be able to register through a dedicated portal, following which the government would allocate plantation sites and schedules.

In Kalkaji, Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra joined South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri in a cleanliness and plantation drive. Referring to Prime Minister Modi's tenure, Mishra said the country had witnessed an era of transformation marked by welfare measures, self-reliance and strengthened national security.

Taking a political swipe

at the Opposition over the O-Zone issue, Mishra said, "Had the Opposition acted in the interest of O-Zone residents while in power, it would not have to resort to the drama of a signature campaign today."

He reiterated that the Delhi government would not allow "even a single brick of any house to be disturbed" in the name of the O-Zone.

Health Minister Pankaj Singh and Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta led cleanliness drives, with participants pledging support for a cleaner, greener Delhi.

Jan Kalyan camps to serve residents

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major outreach initiative aimed at improving access to welfare services, the Delhi Government will organise Jan Kalyan Shivir at 42 locations across the capital from June 18 to June 20, enabling residents to avail a host of Central and Delhi government schemes under one roof.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the camps are designed to take governance to citizens' doorsteps and ensure that welfare benefits reach eligible beneficiaries without delays. "This is a golden opportunity for people to avail the benefits of various Central and Delhi Government schemes.

Through public participation and good governance, the government is reaching the last person in the queue," she said.

The camps, to function daily from 10 am to 5 pm, will offer on-the-spot assistance for services related to ration cards, Ayushman cards, pensions, Aadhaar registration, Jan Dhan accounts, e-Shram cards, PM SVANidhi, PM Vishwakarma and PM Surya Ghar schemes, among others.

"Eligible citizens should visit their nearest Jan Kalyan Shivir and take advantage of these facilities. These camps reflect our commitment to transparency, public service and inclusive governance," the Chief Minister said.

Min finds major lapses during surprise inspection of fire stn

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood on Wednesday conducted a surprise inspection of the Naraina Fire Station and flagged serious shortcomings in infrastructure, documentation and modernization, directing immediate action against officials responsible for negligence.

The inspection was aimed at assessing the station's operational preparedness, response mechanisms, equipment status and manpower deployment. During the visit, Sood reviewed fire tenders, rescue equipment and communication systems to evaluate the station's readiness to respond to emergencies.

The minister observed that several critical operational



tools were missing, including the primary jurisdiction map and inventory records. He also expressed concern over the poor condition of the fire station building, describing it as being in a state of severe neglect.

"The safety of citizens is paramount and no laxity will be tolerated in emergency response capabilities," Sood said, directing senior Delhi

Fire Services officials to immediately bridge gaps in technology, documentation and infrastructure.

Expressing dissatisfaction over the condition of the facility, the Home Minister said departments responsible for maintenance must be held accountable. He ordered strict administrative action against officials found negligent in maintaining safety and operational standards.

Sood also interacted with fire station personnel to understand their equipment requirements, operational challenges and maintenance needs, while reviewing staffing levels and resource allocation to ensure fire stations are adequately equipped to meet the city's emergency demands.

Capital records below-normal temperatures; AQI satisfactory

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi was relatively pleasant on Wednesday, with the mercury staying below normal across most weather stations, even as the city witnessed a rise in daytime temperatures after recording its coolest day of June a day earlier.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Safdarjung, the city's primary weather station, recorded a maximum temperature of 38.1 degrees Celsius, 0.7 notches below normal, while the minimum settled at 23.8 degrees Celsius, 3.7 notches below normal.

Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 37.6 degrees Celsius, 1.6 notches below normal, and a minimum of 22.3 degrees Celsius, 5.5 notches below normal. Lodhi Road registered a maximum of 38 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 22.6 degrees Celsius, both below normal by a degree and 5.4 degrees respectively.

The Ridge observatory recorded the highest maximum temperature at 39.2 degrees Celsius, marginally above normal by 0.9 degree, while its minimum temperature stood at 22 degrees Celsius, 4.8 notches below normal. Ayanagar recorded a maximum



HIGHLIGHTS

- » The weather department said Safdarjung received 2.8 mm of rainfall during the 24-hour period ending at 8:30 am on Wednesday
- » Palam recorded 9.1 mm of rainfall, Lodhi Road 1.2 mm, Ayanagar 2.5 mm, while the Ridge station recorded a trace of rainfall in said period
- » The Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 92, in the 'satisfactory' category

temperature of 37.4 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches below normal, and a minimum of 22.2

degrees Celsius, 3.7 degrees below normal.

The weather department said Safdarjung received 2.8 mm of rainfall during the 24-hour period ending at 8:30 am on Wednesday. Palam recorded 9.1 mm of rainfall, Lodhi Road 1.2 mm, Ayanagar 2.5 mm, while the Ridge station recorded a trace of rainfall during the said period.

The Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 92, in the "satisfactory" category, at 4 pm, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered "good", 51 and 100 "satisfactory", 101 and 200 "moderate", 201 and 300 "poor", 301 and 400 "very poor", and 401 and 500 "severe".

AIIMS, Intuitive launch robotic surgery training centre

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, and healthcare technology company Intuitive have signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to establish the AIIMS da Vinci Robotic-Assisted Surgery Training Centre, aimed at expanding training in robotic-assisted procedures across specialties such as urology, gynaecology and general surgery.

Speaking on the initiative, Dr Rajeev Kumar, Senior Professor of Urology at AIIMS, said robotic surgery has been available at the institute for nearly two decades and that the new centre is focused on enhancing training capacity rather than introducing the technology itself.

He said patients undergoing surgery for conditions such as prostate, kidney and bladder cancer stand to benefit significantly from robotic-assisted procedures.

According to Dr Kumar, robotic surgery is particularly useful in complex laparoscopic operations where conventional laparoscopy can be technically demanding.

The dedicated training cen-

tre houses two robotic systems from different manufacturers that will be used exclusively for training purposes, allowing surgeons and healthcare teams to gain hands-on experience without practising on patients.

Addressing common misconceptions, Dr Kumar emphasised that the robot does not perform surgery independently.

"The robot is only a tool operated by the surgeon. The surgery is ultimately performed by the surgeon," he said.

He noted that robotic systems offer advantages such as reduced surgeon fatigue, enhanced visualisation and greater precision during complex procedures. However, he said the high cost of robotic surgery remains the biggest obstacle to its wider adoption in India.

Dr Kumar also welcomed the growing role of artificial intelligence in healthcare, saying technologies that make procedures safer and more efficient should be embraced.

The new centre is expected to help build a larger pool of surgeons trained in robotic-assisted surgery and support the advancement of technology-driven healthcare in India.

PWD revisits material & stitching standards for giant tricolour flags

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The recent damage to Delhi's giant tricolours in strong winds has prompted the city government to rethink how the national flags are sourced and maintained. Instead of simply replacing the torn flags, the Public Works Department (PWD) is now undertaking a scientific review of the material, stitching quality and replacement cycle of the flags, with plans to build stricter standards into future contracts.

PWD Minister Parvesh Verma said the government has initiated a detailed exercise to determine the most suitable specifications for the flags installed across the Capital.

"Scientific studies are currently being conducted on the thread material, size and stitching of the flags. We have provided samples of the existing flags to the contractor, who will submit five different samples. These will then undergo testing before a final decision is taken," Verma told *Millennium Post*.

The minister said the review would also revisit maintenance norms that were followed under the existing system.

"Earlier, the norm was that each flag could be washed up to five times and only four new



flags were replaced in a year. Contractors used to supply substandard material," he said.

According to Verma, the revised tender will adopt a more technical approach, recognising that flags installed on different-sized poles face varying levels of stress.

"The size of the flags varies according to the height of the poles, larger poles require larger flags, while smaller poles need smaller ones. We will now scientifically determine the appropriate GSM required for flags installed on different poles and incorporate these specifications into the new tender," he said.

He added that the government is also considering increasing the frequency of replacement.

"We are also consider-

ing reducing the permissible washing limit and increasing the number of replacements from the current four times a year. Once the sample testing is complete, we will decide how frequently the flags should be changed," Verma said.

The move comes after the PWD decided to temporarily bring down all large national flags installed at around 500 prominent locations across Delhi after several were damaged during recent spells of strong winds and thunderstorms. Officials earlier said the 115-foot-high flagpoles, installed under the previous AAP government's 'Deshbhakti' initiative launched in 2022, use polyester flags intended to withstand regular wear and tear. However, the recent weather conditions exposed their limitations.

PWD teams have been deployed to inspect damaged installations and replace torn flags. The tricolours will be re-hoisted once the India Meteorological Department's thunderstorm warnings are lifted. Officials maintained that the display and installation of the national flags have been carried out in accordance with the provisions of the Flag Code of India, 2002.

PITCHES FOR GLOBAL FRAMEWORK TO BOOST TRADE & CONNECTIVITY

PM Modi flags concerns over impact of West Asia crisis

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday proposed a framework to boost connectivity and trade by combining the strengths of the G7 nations, India and the Global South even as he flagged concerns over long-lasting consequences of the West Asia crisis on developing countries.

The Prime Minister floated the proposal for setting up the International Mobilisation Partnership for Accelerating Connectivity and Trade (IMPACT) while speaking at an outreach session of the G7 summit in this French commune.

Modi emphasised that modern economic growth cannot be measured solely by trade volume or GDP numbers and that the true value of progress lies in its direction, and who ultimately benefits from it.

The impact of the West



Prime Minister Narendra Modi attends a working session at the G7 Summit, in Evian-les-Bains, France PTI

Asian crisis on fuel, fertiliser, and food supply chains will have long-lasting consequences for the Global South, Modi said, adding the most vulnerable countries should not bear the burden of geopolitical crises.

"If we truly want to strengthen international sol-

idity, the most vulnerable countries should not bear the burden of these crises alone," he said.

"Our international financial institutions must create support mechanisms that help developing countries absorb these shocks and maintain their eco-

Highlights

» Modi emphasised that modern economic growth cannot be measured solely by trade volume or GDP numbers

» If we truly want to strengthen international solidarity, the most vulnerable countries should not bear the burden of these crises alone, PM said

nommic resilience," Modi said.

The prime minister said the new framework to help the Global South can be modelled on the ambitious IMEC or India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor initiative.

"Drawing inspiration from the IMEC vision, we can work

on connectivity projects with countries in Africa, Latin America, and the Pacific Islands," he said.

Combining the capital of the G7, India's talent, and the ownership of countries in the Global South, we could consider creating the International Mobilisation Partnership for Accelerating Connectivity and Trade, or IMPACT, he said.

"Its objective should be to create corridors that connect trade, technology, energy, and opportunity," he said.

The IMEC initiative was firmuped up on the sidelines of the G20 Summit in Delhi in 2023.

Billed as a pathbreaking initiative, it envisages vast road, railroad and shipping networks among Saudi Arabia, India, the United States and Europe with an aim to ensure integration among Asia, the Middle East and the West.

AGENCIES

India always on side of peace: Modi after talks with Zelenskyy

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: India will "always be" on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Wednesday after holding talks with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

Modi met Zelenskyy on the sidelines of the G7 summit in the French commune of Evian-Les-Bains.

"Met President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Evian. In recent times, India and Ukraine have been engaging extensively. This has been reflected in different areas of our cooperation," Modi said in a post on X.

"Our talks today were about reviewing different aspects of our cooperation. We both agree that trade ties need to be restored to what they were in the pre-war time. Also reiterated that India will always be on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else," he said.

India has been consistently calling for an end to the Russia-Ukraine conflict through dialogue and diplomacy.



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on the sidelines of the G7 Summit, in Evian-les-Bains, France PTI

After the meeting, Zelenskyy said that India and Ukraine have "great potential for cooperation", and are already implementing joint projects.

"Today, we discussed how to give them even more substance and expand cooperation across various sectors. Importantly, the Prime Minister is interested in developing mutually beneficial relations with Ukraine and sees that this part-

nership can make our people stronger.

"There are good industrial and other projects that we can implement together. We agreed that our teams would work through all the details," he said on X.

Modi and Zelenskyy last held direct communication when the Ukrainian leader dialled him on August 30 last year.

After the phone conversation, Zelenskyy said India is ready to make the necessary efforts and to deliver the appropriate signal to Russia.

Modi met Russian President Vladimir Putin two days after the call.

In July 2024, Modi travelled to Moscow and told Putin that a solution to the Ukraine conflict is not possible on the battlefield and peace efforts do not succeed in the midst of bombs and bullets.

The next month, Modi visited the Ukrainian capital city of Kyiv and conveyed to Zelenskyy that both Ukraine and Russia should sit together without wasting time to end the war. AGENCIES

Justice Narasimha-led bench to hear plea concerning NEET-UG in July: SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A bench headed by Justice P S Narasimha will hear in July a plea challenging the decision to conduct NEET-UG 2026 re-test, the Supreme Court said on Wednesday.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency (NTA) had cancelled the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak.

The CBI is currently investigating the matter, and a re-test is scheduled for June 21.

On Wednesday, a plea seeking quashing of the decision to re-conduct the NEET-UG 2026 came up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana.

The CJ said the plea would be heard by a bench headed by Justice Narasimha in July when the apex court resumes normal



The plea has sought quashing of the decision to re-conduct NEET-UG 2026

functioning after the partial court working days.

The Justice Narasimha-led bench is already seized of separate petitions related to the NEET-UG.

The fresh plea has sought a direction to the Centre and others to implement secure technology-driven digital examination and evaluation mech-

anisms, including encrypted digital question delivery systems, biometric authentication, AI-assisted monitoring and secure computer-based examination infrastructure for future national-level exams.

It also sought a direction to the Centre to constitute an independent expert committee for examining structural, institutional and operational deficiencies in the functioning of the NTA.

The plea has sought quashing of the decision to re-conduct NEET-UG 2026.

As an interim relief, the plea urged the top court to stay the effect of the decision regarding the NEET-UG re-test pending final disposal of the petition.

While hearing a batch of separate pleas related to NEET-UG 2026, the top court on May 29 stressed that the real problem relating to the medical entrance examination would not stop till "actual accountability arises".

Continued from Page 1
The specific structural feature through which the platform has been used to fabricate after-the-event "paper leak" evidence in respect of national examinations, according to an NTA statement.

Telegram has stopped working for existing users in India after the government temporarily restricted access to the app, but it continues to remain operational through Virtual Protocol Network (VPN), according to industry experts.

Google delisted the app on Tuesday, and Apple's Appstore has also removed it now in compliance with the government order to block access to the app, ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination.

Telegram CEO Pavel Durov on Tuesday said the ban on its messaging app by the Indian government will not stop paper leaks, instead move it on to other apps.

In a social media post, Durov said that the decision to ban Telegram for a week punishes over 150 million users of the app in India and not the insiders who leaked the exam materials.

Durov alleged that Reliance Group, in which Meta has a partial stake, may have lobbied, along with its competitor WhatsApp, to impose a ban on the company's app in India.

He also accused Reliance of sabotaging access to Telegram for millions of users outside India (including the UAE).

A senior telecom industry source, who did not wish to be named, termed the allegations as "fake news" as Durov has confused Reliance Communications with Reliance Industries Ltd.

Meanwhile, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal termed "absurd" the Centre's decision to temporarily restrict access to the Telegram

messaging app and claimed that the government has no intention of stopping paper leaks.

In a post on X in Hindi, Kejriwal said, "The Modi government has no intention of stopping paper leaks. That's why such absurd steps are being taken -- transporting papers by Army aircraft and shutting down Telegram. Will these steps stop paper leaks? Absolutely not."

"The paper leak business is a multi-billion-rupee racket. The money goes all the way to the top. If paper leaks are stopped, where will the money come from to buy MLAs/MPs?" he said.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi slammed the government after it temporarily restricted access to Telegram, saying the "new trick" was akin to putting a lock on the victim's house instead of catching the thief.

In a post in Hindi on X, Gandhi said, "Telegram Ban"

-- Modi government's new trick to stop paper leaks. Meaning, instead of catching the thief, just put a lock on the victim's door."

"Lakhs of students have been studying on Telegram for years -- notes, test series, discussions, preparation. How does snatching that facility become the solution to paper leaks? And it's not even fool-proof - every student in the country knows this, and so does the paper leak mafia. So, who will the next ban be on? WhatsApp?" he said.

"On exam day, students will be frisked. Pockets will be cut open with scissors. Question papers will be sent via the Air Force. There won't be any shortage of theatrics. But not a single strike at the root of the disease -- because the paper leak mafia is thriving under this very government's watch, and making the youth weep tears of blood. Modi Ji -- drop the theatrics. Strike at the mafia, not the students."

he said. Listen to the "Chhatron ki goonj (echo of students)" -- or else the youth of the country knows how to claim their rights, Gandhi said. In another post in Hindi, the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said he has set out for Kota, but two names are echoing in his heart -- Umesh and Riya.

"Yesterday, Umesh in Sikar and Riya in Dehradun—both ended their lives under the pressure of Re-NEET. 22- and 23-year-old kids—who were meant to soar in the open skies of their dreams—lost to this unjust system. These deaths are the result of a broken, corrupt system," he said.

"And the ones responsible are the Modi government and Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, who, instead of protecting students, have repeatedly shielded paper leaks, exam mismanagement, and the destroyers of futures," he alleged.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

From Page 1

Strait talk

the US will defend India if anyone attacks it.

In his televised comments, PM Modi complimented Trump for his efforts towards ending the West Asia conflict and brought up the issue of the safety of lakhs of Indian seafarers operating in key maritime zones.

The prime minister hoped that the peace deal with Iran would have provisions for the security of the seafarers.

"Mr President, you and I agree that keeping the Strait of Hormuz open is vital for the global economy. India has consistently emphasised the importance of ensuring freedom of navigation and we should work together on it," he said.

The prime minister, then, underlined the importance of the safety of seafarers.

"Hundreds of thousands of Indian seafarers are working across the global maritime trade routes and their safety is of utmost importance to us. You made tremendous efforts towards reaching this understanding (peace agreement with Iran). I am confident that the issue of safety of seafarers will receive the highest priority in the implementation of this agreement," he said.

In his remarks, Trump described the meeting as "great" and heaped praise on Modi. The US president, without giving any timeline, said he will travel to India.

"People say he is such a nice man. I said he's very very tough. He's a tough negotiator, and he loves the Indian people, but he also loves the US," Trump said.

The US president also described India as a major global player. "I think India plays a big role in everything as long as he (PM Modi) is the leader. India is going to play a big role," Trump said in response to a question on whether New Delhi has a role to play in West Asia.

"As long as I am at the White House, India has a friend in the US," he said, answering a question on the strain in India-US ties.

To a question on the deaths of three Indian seafarers, Trump said he was aware of it. "I heard about that (the deaths), it's a rough profession, no question about it," he said, adding, "We will work together."

Answering another question, Trump said the US will extend support to India if it faces any security challenges or face attack.

The US president also sounded optimistic when asked about the proposed trade deal between India and the US.

Relations witnessed a major downturn after Washington imposed punitive tariffs on India and President Trump made assertions regarding his role in de-escalating the India-Pakistan military clashes of May 2025 that drew sharp reaction from Indian officials.

The Group of 7 (G7) brings together seven of the world's most advanced economies: Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the United Kingdom and the United States. The European Union is also a member of the bloc.

PM Modi arrived in Evian-les-Bains after concluding his two-day trip to Slovakia.

Trump

Aaron David Miller, who served as an adviser on Middle East issues to Democratic and Republican administrations over two decades.

An agreement is scheduled to be signed on Friday in the Burgenstock resort near the city of Luzern. Speaking on Tuesday at the annual G7 summit in France, Trump said he told Netanyahu that he's been unhappy with his recent moves.

"Without the US, there would be no Israel. Without me, there would be no Israel because no other president was willing to do what I did," Trump said. "I have had a great relationship with Bibi. Now Bibi has to be more responsible with respect to Lebanon."

There has long been a bipartisan consensus around supporting Israel in Washington, but that has frayed in recent years. Liberals have been increasingly outraged by Israel's treatment of Palestinians, especially during the war in Gaza, and conservatives have questioned the importance of longstanding American support for Israel. There are concerns about antisemitism on the left and the right.

Trump's latest comments drew swift criticism from left-leaning groups.

"He is framing Israel's mere existence as contingent on him," said Halie Soifer, who leads the Jewish Democratic Council of America. "It's deeply offensive to the vast majority of Jews who care about Israel's future."

President Joe Biden and Vice President Kamala Harris often disagreed with Netanyahu during the war in Gaza, and sometimes they criticised him publicly. But they were more circumspect to avoid facing accusations of being anti-Israel.

Conservative, pro-Israel groups were divided on the seriousness of Trump's public condemnation of Netanyahu.

Republican Jewish Coalition President Matt Brooks described Trump's criticism as little more than the inevitable disagreement among family members.

Brooks dismissed that any muted criticism of Trump's comments from his party represented a mixed political message because Trump has been reliably supportive of Israel as president.

"If Biden or Harris said something critical, it came from the position of someone who was hostile toward or didn't have the same level of support for Israel that President Trump has," Brooks said.

He noted the first Trump administration's role in moving the US embassy in Israel from Tel Aviv to Jerusalem and the return of Israeli hostages from Gaza during the president's second term, among other acts.

Biden had criticised Netanyahu's handling of the war in Gaza, though Trump's criticism of Netanyahu comes with a "tremendous reservoir of goodwill on this issue that neither Biden nor Harris ever had."

Pro-Israel advocate Mort Klein said Trump should have kept the comments private, especially in light of his public praise over the years of authoritarian leaders in Turkey, North Korea and China.

Klein, president of the conservative Zionist Organisation of America, said he worried that Trump was making the comments in public to appeal to Israel critics "because he sees that Americans have become more hostile toward Israel than they've ever been."

"That worries me," Klein said.

Hill station rush

He said three cranes have been stationed in different sectors to swiftly handle such situations.

Five vehicles had broken down on Tuesday, he said, adding that private buses stopping at unauthorised points often impede traffic flow. Idle parking is another issue being dealt with.

The traffic management strategy includes deployment of an additional 210 police personnel and home guards, besides volunteers. Traffic personnel have also been deployed at major parking sites to ensure smooth entry and exit of vehicles and prevent congestion.

The number of bike-borne traffic personnel has been increased to 32 for rapid response to traffic-related situations. Interceptor vehicles are being operated in several areas to enforce traffic regulations and ensure swift action against violations.

Shimla city has been divided into five sectors to ensure better monitoring and regulation of traffic. Each sector has been assigned to a gazetted officer whose primary responsibility is to ensure smooth movement of traffic within the respective sector.

Moreover, tourists are being encouraged to use alternative routes to save time and reduce congestion within the city. Travel-

lers heading towards Kufri, Narkanda, Theog and Kinnaur have been advised to use the Shoghi-Mehli bypass route.

Use of the route reduces traffic pressure within the city and saves travel time, the official said, adding that at present, around 800 vehicles are being diverted through the bypass route every day.

Shimla Police is also creating and sharing awareness and educational videos on social media platforms to provide traffic-related information to tourists and the public.

To encourage use of public transport, large vehicles such as Travellers and other public transport have been permitted to operate on Cart Road to reduce reliance on private vehicles and ease congestion.

Highlighting the efficacy of the plan, SP Singh said during the peak summer tourism season between April and June, there has no instance of major traffic congestion in the district -- especially in Shimla city and its outskirts.

He said last year, huge traffic jams were reported at the peripheral roads towards Shoghi, Kufri and Bilaspur, besides the main Shimla city.

Shimla Police, while extending a warm welcome to tourists, has appealed to visitors and residents alike to follow traffic regulations, use designated parking areas and adhere to alternative routes to ensure smooth traffic flow in the tourist hotspot.

PTI

FACING A REVOLT?

We are not breaking the party. By 2027, they will leave on their own. What has happened to the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, the Samajwadi Party will face an even worse fate in the upcoming Assembly elections," the Maurya claimed.

Rajbhar echoed the sentiment on Wednesday, drawing parallels with the political turmoil in Maharashtra and the rebellion in the Trinamool Congress.

"Do not keep your attention only on Maharashtra. Uttar Pradesh is next. Only when someone is ready to be bought can someone buy them," Rajbhar told reporters, suggesting that divisions within the Akhilesh Yadav-led SP could soon come to the surface.

He also alleged that senior SP leader Ram Gopal Yadav had secretly written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, naming leaders who were willing to switch sides while seeking protection for himself. Rajbhar did not provide any evidence to substantiate the allegation. The coordinated attacks from two senior members of the state government came amid heightened political activity as parties prepare for the 2027 Assembly elections.

Responding to the claims at a press conference at the Samajwadi Party's state headquarters here, Akhilesh Yadav dismissed the predictions of a split and accused the BJP of relying on coercion to weaken opposition parties.

With a smile, he remarked, "Gaana aur daana, kab tak chalega ye afsana."

Akhilesh alleged that the BJP had previously broken away Samajwadi Party MLAs and members of the Legislative Council by offering inducements and using intimidation.

"They lured and threatened MLAs and MLCs. Those who are afraid will leave, but politics needs courageous people," he said.

The SP chief also claimed that it was the BJP, not his party, that was facing internal discontent. "BJP's own MLAs are waiting to switch sides. Some people reveal their cards only at the right time," he said.

Rejecting the ministers' claims, Akhilesh asserted that his party remained united and had weathered several political challenges in the past.

The exchange signals that the contest ahead of the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections is increasingly shifting beyond electoral issues to a battle over political stability, defections and the opposition's ability to remain united against the BJP.

Starting at an imminent split,

the Shiv Sena (UBT) on Wednesday issued a whip directing its MPs to attend a meeting in New Delhi to discuss 'important issues,' a move aimed at paving the way for disqualification proceedings against rebel leaders.

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut alleged that some Maharashtra MPs were being offered "Rs 50 crore" and dared the rebels to quit if they want to switch sides, saying workers of the Uddhav Thackeray-led party toiled for their victory. He also warned that the people of Maharashtra and Sena (UBT) workers will not spare the rebels if any attempts are made to replicate the split in the party, like the one in 2022.

The Sena (UBT) is staring at a crisis, with "six to seven" of its nine Lok Sabha MPs inclined to switch to the Eknath Shinde-led ruling Shiv Sena and camping in Delhi, as per sources.

As Raut addressed a press conference in the national capital, only three Sena (UBT) Lok Sabha MPs were present. Raut, however, maintained he still does not have any official information on the MPs switching sides.

The Rajya Sabha member claimed pressure tactics and money were at play to lure the party MPs.

The Sena (UBT) has nine MPs in the Lok Sabha, and at least two thirds of them would be required to form a separate group. Apart from Desai, Waje and Sawant, the other six MPs are Sanjay Patil, Sanjay Deshmukh, Omprakash Rajee Nimalkar, Bhauasaheb Wakchoure, Nagesh Patil-Ashstikar and Sanjay Jadhav.

Raut, in a post on X, took a swipe at those planning to rebel against the party leadership, saying "everything will be accounted for."

The party had issued a similar whip when 39 MLAs led by Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde rebelled against the Sena leadership in 2022, following which disqualification proceedings were initiated against them.

The split in the Shiv Sena (UBT) gained traction when five MPs skipped a meeting called by Thackeray on Sunday and attended it virtually. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

'PUTS PRESSURE ON CHILDREN'

‘Children are being crushed’: Rahul on India’s education system at Kota rally

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOTA: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday described India's education system as a "rejection system" rather than a selection system, alleging that it places excessive financial burden and stress on students and middle-class families.

Addressing a gathering in the coaching hub of Kota, Gandhi said that the current education structure is "extremely stressful and unfair".

"India's education system is an extortion machine. We want a system that allows you to dream big," he said, adding that young people in the country are being subjected to too much pain, stress and unhappiness. The leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said that India's education system puts pressure on children, stresses them and crushes them.

"This is not good for the



Rahul Gandhi interacts with students during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' rally in Kota

PTI

Highlights

- » After the opening remarks, five students -- three girls and two boys -- were called onto the stage for interaction. They are NEET, JEE and civil services aspirants
- » "This is not a political meeting. This is a meeting about you, about the young people who are struggling to get a future," he said.

country. I want all of us to work together to ensure that no student in this country ever feels what this girl felt," he said at "Chhatron ki Goonj" Maha Rally in Kota where he interacted with students on various issues like paper leaks and unemployment.

"This is not a political meet-

ing. This is a meeting about you, about the young people who are struggling to get a future. This evening is about you, the challenges that you are dealing with every single day," he said in his opening remarks.

He claimed that the system pushes students mainly towards a few career paths such

as engineering, medical and civil services, while discouraging alternative aspirations.

"Why is India only asking children to do five things? The answer is money, because the system makes money through these five routes," he alleged.

Gandhi explained five paths of SSC, UPSC, RRB, JEE and

NEET through a presentation.

He said lakhs of students are compelled to spend large sums on schooling, coaching institutes, uniforms and hostel facilities, with no guarantee of success in competitive examinations. He cited examinations such as NEET, JEE, UPSC Civil Services Examination, SSC Exam and RRB, saying that lakhs of candidates compete for a very limited number of successful outcomes. "For NEET alone, around 22 lakh students appear, but less than one lakh get selected. These are extremely difficult odds," he said.

Gandhi said that such patterns make the system brutal and exclusionary. He further alleged that the education economy extracts large amounts of money from families each year.

He called for structural reforms to expand opportunities and reduce dependence on high-pressure examinations.

PM to unveil Rs 2.4K crore PM-VBRY payout for beneficiaries

First-time employees are eligible for incentive of up to Rs 15K

OUR CORRESPONDENT



PM Narendra Modi on the sidelines of the G7 summit on Wednesday

AP/PTI

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will disburse incentives worth around Rs 2,400 crore under the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana (PM-VBRY) at a special programme to be held in Delhi on Friday.

The disbursal marks a significant milestone in the implementation of PM-VBRY, the government of India's flagship employment-linked incentive scheme aimed at accelerating job creation, promoting formalisation of employment, enhancing employability, and expanding social security coverage across sectors, an official statement said.

The scheme has already supported the creation of 15 lakh employment opportunities across the country.

The PM-VBRY is designed to encourage both workers and employers to participate in the formal economy.

Under the scheme, first-

time employees are eligible for an incentive of up to Rs 15,000, providing crucial support as they enter the workforce. Employers generating additional employment are eligible for incentives of up to Rs 3,000 per month per additional employee, thereby encouraging sustained job creation.

Recognising the strategic importance of manufacturing in driving economic growth, employers in the manufacturing sector are eligible to receive incentives for a period of four years, while employers in all other sectors can avail incen-

The scheme has already supported the creation of 15 lakh employment opportunities across the country

tives for two years, the statement said.

The scheme reflects the government's commitment to fostering an enabling ecosystem for employment-led growth and ensuring that the benefits of India's economic progress translate into quality formal employment opportunities for its youth.

The PM-VBRY came into effect on August 1, 2025. With a total outlay of Rs 99,446 crore, the scheme aims to incentivise the creation of more than 3.5 crore jobs over a two-year period.

‘On right track’: Annamalai signals July roll-out for party

CHENNAI: His "We the Leaders" movement launched recently was on the "right track" to transition into a political party by July and the goal is to achieve 50 lakh membership, former BJP Tamil Nadu president K Annamalai said on Wednesday.

Pointing out that at present 18 lakh members have joined the organisation "without any expectations," Annamalai, in a video interaction on a social media platform, said that membership was taking place not only online but also by meeting the people directly.

Stating that the members have joined with the belief that the movement would bring in a big change, he said "after we

He pointed out that at present 18 lakh members have joined the organisation

start this movement as a political outfit, its activities will take on a different nature from this July and people are going to see it."

Claiming that his movement "will not fail, will not lie, and will not lead the people to the wrong path", Annamalai said "for us, we are equal to all religions and there is no second thought about that".

"Our aim in the coming

months is that this membership drive will keep going", he said. "As we move forward, our objective is to transform our organisation into a people's movement to talk about the various issues in the state".

Raising various issues, especially drug menace among the youth in the state, Annamalai said this will be taken up as a mass public movement at the grassroots level.

He also said that technocrats are bewildered not knowing how to enter politics. "Between 40 and 50 years of age, Tamil people, who have achieved a lot, across the globe including in US and London do not know how to enter politics here".

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Wednesday accused Home Minister Amit Shah of launching an "onslaught" on the Opposition and "wrecking" Indian democracy to compensate for his "humiliation" in the Lok Sabha on April 17 this year when he failed to get the Constitution amendment bill passed.

The opposition party said Shah's allurements are enticing a number of those who were elected just two years ago on a strong anti-BJP agenda to now join the BJP. The Congress asserted that Shah will not succeed in his ultimate objective.

The Congress' attack came after Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut on late Tuesday night claimed that an "advance of Rs 15 crore" is being given to "buy MPs from Maharashtra", adding fuel

‘Telegram ban another stunt’

New Delhi: Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Wednesday took a swipe at the Centre after it temporarily restricted access to Telegram, saying the move is only to be added to a long list of other "stunts" that have preoccupied the Narendra Modi government since the cancellation of the NEET-UG exam last month. "The Prime Minister's go-to man on all scientific matters and a very distinguished mathematician otherwise is being held to account by Gen Z youngsters," Ramesh said. "The Telegram ban is only to be added to a long list of other stunts (IAF transportation of question papers, the announcement that the PM is personally monitoring the situation) that have preoccupied the Modi government since the cancellation of the NEET-UG exam last month. It is far more important to ban the Teleprompter," Ramesh added.

AGENCIES

to the intense buzz that a section of party's Lok Sabha members could switch sides.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said the Union Home Minister is continuing his

onslaught on the Opposition and his wrecking of Indian democracy to compensate for his humiliation in the Lok Sabha when he failed to have the Delimitation Bills passed.

Akali Dal Waris Punjab De seeks FIR against CM Mann over Akal Takht order

HOSHIARPUR: The Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) led by jailed MP Amritpal Singh on Wednesday held a protest here demanding an FIR against Bhagwant Mann, two days after the Akal Takht declared the Punjab chief minister 'anti-Guru' and 'anti-Khalsa Panth' over an objectionable video.

Akal Takht, the highest temporal seat of Sikhs, on Monday declared Mann 'Guru Dokhi' (anti-Guru) and 'Khalsa Panth Virodhi' (anti-Khalsa Panth), and directed community members to "shun ties" with him after the chief minister was accused of lying about a purported objectionable video that hurt Sikh sentiments.

The Sikh clergy maintained that forensic reports commis-

sioned by it concluded that the viral clip was authentic and not AI-generated, even as Mann said the person in the clip was not him. The protesters, led by Waris Punjab De district president Avtar Singh Sekhon, raised slogans against Mann and also burnt his effigy.

They later submitted a memorandum to Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria through the assistant commissioner, demanding the registration of a case against Mann, an independent inquiry into the matter and his resignation on moral grounds.

Lakhbir Singh, the party's in-charge for the Sham Churasi Assembly segment, Talwinder Singh Nijjar, member of a five-member committee

of the Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De), and Karnail Singh Lovely, the Hoshiarpur president of the outfit, joined the protesters.

The leaders demanded that based on forensic reports and facts related to the controversial video, a case should be registered against Mann under the relevant provisions of law.

They also demanded that a probe be conducted in the matter under the supervision of a sitting judge of the Punjab and Haryana High Court. The CM should resign on moral grounds and apologise for the objectionable video, they said.

The matter stems from the summoning of Mann by the Akal Takht in January this year for allegedly making comments on 'Guru ki GolaK'.

MPOST

‘Food grain production in country by 71% over past 12 years’

PATNA: Union Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Wednesday said that food grain production in the country has increased by 71 per cent over the past 12 years.

Addressing a press conference here, Chouhan said, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, several agricultural reforms and policies have been brought to benefit farmers as well as to increase food grain production.

"The country has witnessed a 71 per cent increase in food grain production over the last 12 years. The government's focus has consistently remained on fulfilling public aspirations. This 12-year tenure of Modi ji is the golden era of India's reconstruction and the fulfilment of public aspirations," the Union minister said.

The Modi government's mantra of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas', has transformed the lives of villagers, poor, farmers, women, and youth, he added.

Our PM has scripted a new saga of development and public welfare from Jan Dhan accounts to Ayushman Bharat, and from PM Awas Yojana to Digital India revolution, etc, said Chouhan also the Union Rural Development minister.

Under Modi ji's leadership, the country is advancing toward the goal of a Developed India, he said. Schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana and PM-Kisan, he said, have brought transformative changes to the lives of farmers.

He further said the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) will be implemented across the country from July 1 this year. He also said that all pending payments under MGNREGA will be cleared before June 30.

Earlier, he held a high-level meeting in Patna to review various issues related to Bihar's agriculture and rural development sectors.

AGENCIES

Ram temple donation row: Akhilesh slams BJP, adds ‘land grab’ charge

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday escalated his attack on the BJP over the Ram temple donation row, questioning the alleged lack of transparency in the management of donations and claiming land-related irregularities in Ayodhya.

Yadav's comments came days after the Uttar Pradesh government established a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to investigate allegations of embezzlement of donations made to the Ram temple and issues concerning the financial management of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

Addressing a press conference at party headquarters here, Yadav claimed that CCTV



footage related to the alleged irregularities was missing and that transparency was absent in handling donations. "People are asking why no proper account is being provided. Questions are being raised about donations, offerings, and other funds," he stated.

The SP chief also alleged

that complaints about land-grabbing incidents and irregularities in Ayodhya had consistently been brought to the government's attention.

Claiming that locals and party workers had shared information with the opposition, Yadav alleged that several people had lost possession of their land and appealed to residents to provide details of alleged cases of land acquisition and demolition of houses so that the issues could be documented and raised before the government.

He accused the BJP of being more concerned with money than religion and said that people wanted development, prosperity, relief from inflation and an end to divisive politics.

MPOST

J'khand RS polls: Numbers game begins

Stage set for election to two Rajya Sabha seats amid fear of cross-voting

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RANCHI: All preparations have been completed to conduct the election to two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand on Thursday, for which three candidates are in the fray, an official said.

The opposition BJP-led NDA decided to support an Independent candidate, despite lacking the required number of MLAs in the assembly.

Three candidates – JMM's Baidyanath Ram, Congress's Pranav Jha and BJP-backed Independent nominee Parimal Nathwani – are contesting the polls for the two seats.

The voting will take place between 9 am and 4 pm at a polling station set up within the Jharkhand Assembly premises.

"Once the polling is over, the report will be sent to the Election Commission of India. On the Commission's permission, the counting of votes will start, tentatively around 5 pm," Returning Officer Ranjit Kumar said on Wednesday.

Kumar, who is also the secretary of the Jharkhand assembly, said all preparations are

Key Points

- » The opposition BJP-led NDA decided to support an Independent candidate, despite lacking the required number of MLAs in the assembly
- » Three candidates – JMM's Baidyanath

Ram, Congress's Pranav Jha and BJP-backed Independent nominee Parimal Nathwani – are contesting the polls for the two seats

» All eyes are on the second seat, which will be a tough fight between Congress's Jha and NDA-backed Nathwani.

in place to hold the polling peacefully.

The returning officer added that adequate security arrangements have been made in the Assembly premises in view of the elections.

Political temperatures are rising in the state capital amid fear of cross-voting.

A candidate is required to secure a minimum of 28 first-preference votes to emerge victorious in the June 18 polls.

The BJP-led NDA has 24 MLAs in the Jharkhand assembly, while the INDIA bloc has 56 members.

The JMM's Baidyanath Ram is expected to win easily, as the party has adequate numbers in the state assembly.

All eyes are on the second seat, in which a tough fight between Congress's Jha and NDA-backed Nathwani is likely.

In the Jharkhand Assembly, the INDIA bloc has 56 members, comprising 34 from the JMM, 16 from the Congress, four from the RJD and two from CPI(ML) Liberation.

The NDA has 24 MLAs -- 21 from the BJP and one each from the LJP (Ram Vilas), AJSU Party and the JD(U). The Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha has one MLA.

Both the ruling and opposition camps are leaving no stone unturned to keep their MLAs intact ahead of the polling.

The NDA MLAs were

shifted to a hotel in Ranchi on Tuesday, while the ruling INDIA bloc is busy holding meetings with its MLAs to thwart chances of cross-voting.

The ruling INDIA bloc MLAs, including those from the Congress, participated in a mock poll during a meeting at Chief Minister Hemant Soren's residence on Tuesday night to make the new legislators aware of the exercise.

Congress MLA Suresh Baitha said a meeting of ruling party legislators, including those from RJD and CPI(ML) Liberation, was held at a hotel on Wednesday, and they also participated in a mock poll on that occasion.

"We all 56 MLAs of the INDIA bloc are united, and we will win both the Rajya Sabha seats," he said.

BJP chief whip Naveen Jaiswal also claimed victory for their supported candidate in the election.

One of the Rajya Sabha seats in the state fell vacant following the death of JMM co-founder Shibui Soren. The other vacancy is due to the completion of BJP member Deepak Prakash's tenure on June 21.

TN: Guv address to share TVK's vision?

CHENNAI: The Governor's address to the Tamil Nadu Assembly on Thursday has a few firsts-- Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar's first customary address to the House, as well as the maiden Governor's address of the ruling TVK where the government is expected to detail its blueprint for the state's development. Also, it comes close on the heels of the Vande Mataram row, where relegating the Tamil invocation song after the national song stirred a controversy.

After the April 23 polls, C Joseph Vijay-led TVK emerged as the single largest party by securing 108 seats, which was not enough to prove majority in the House. However, with the support of Congress, VCK, two Left parties and IUM, Vijay comfortably won the floor test to form the new government. A section of the AIADMK MLAs also voted in his favour. The 17th Assembly session also assumes significance as most of the TVK MLAs are new to the House.

However, they were given a two-day training programme on the rules.

AGENCIES

Nation Briefs

CPI(M) SLAMS TELANGANA CM OVER NAMING ROAD AFTER TRUMP

NEW DELHI: After the BJP's criticism, the CPI(M) also slammed Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Wednesday over the state's decision to name a road adjoining the US Consulate in Hyderabad after US President Donald Trump, and hoped the Congress high command would "make sure that it is withdrawn". In a post on X, CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby contrasted the move with the renaming of Harrington Street outside the US Consulate in Kolkata as Ho Chi Minh Sarani during the Vietnam War. "At the height of the American war in Vietnam, India renamed Harrington Street outside the US Consulate in Kolkata as Ho Chi Minh Sarani, in honour of the great anti-imperialist leader," he said.

TN CONG LEADER JOTHIMANI ASKS DMK TO STOP TARGETING RAHUL GANDHI

KARUR: Slamming DMK's Tamil mouthpiece 'Murasoli' for targeting senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Karur MP Jothimani on Wednesday said her party's silence must not be mistaken for weakness. Speaking to reporters, Jothimani said the strong attack on Rahul by the DMK's daily newspaper was not acceptable. She said her party could give a fitting reply, but was holding back in view of its long-standing ties with the DMK through thick and thin. At a time when the DMK had lost polls and most of its allies, "we feel that they are angered and it is natural," she said. But criticism of Rahul was not acceptable under any circumstances.

'INDIA HAS EMERGED AS STRONG & SECURE NATION'

Shah highlights govt's national security achievements of 12 yrs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Wednesday highlighted the achievements of the Narendra Modi-led government in strengthening national security over the past 12 years, asserting that India has emerged as a strong and secure nation capable of protecting its citizens and responding decisively to threats.

On social media platform X, Shah described the nation as now a stronghold of safety during Modi's leadership. Because of multiple strategic moves and missions, he noted, India's defence systems have strengthened along with its position worldwide.

From time to time, actions shaped national defence strategies. Surgical interventions marked one phase. Aerial operations followed another path entirely. Code-named moves entered public memory differently. One such instance carried the label Operation Sindoor. These were responses framed around border tensions. Authority figures pointed to them clearly. Among those speaking was Shah.



Shah reviews cyber crime helpline 1930

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday reviewed the functioning of the National Cyber Crime Helpline 1930 and directed officials to further strengthen and modernise the system to enhance protection for citizens against cyber crimes,

His references included constitutional changes too. The removal of special status in Jammu and Kashmir stood out.

particularly cyber financial frauds.

Not long ago, Shah looked at how well different systems work to help people affected by online crimes right away. What stands out is his point about the govt's push under Modi to shape a system powered by tech, focused on citizens, keeping them safe from digital threats nationwide.

Legal shifts unfolded under Article 370's end. Parallel attempts targeted internal unrest. Left-wing extremism met focused

resistance. Systematic steps spread through multiple regions. Security frameworks evolved without pause. Each move tied back to broader stability goals.

Stability in the northeast has grown, says the Home minister, following over a dozen peace deals sealed across ten years. Not one but several of these understandings, he adds, played key roles in easing armed resistance. Lasting calm, rather than mere pauses in conflict, emerged under their influence. Development followed where violence once held ground.

From Shah's perspective, India's stance on national security during the Modi administration shows consistent effort toward protecting sovereign priorities alongside public well-being. Examples drawn from recent defence policies reveal firmness when confronting cross-border tensions or domestic unrest instead of mere reaction. Global observers have noted such moves as markers of strategic clarity rather than isolated responses. The framework built over these years rests less on rhetoric but more on executed choices across multiple domains.

FINANCIAL YEAR 2025-26

Defence production surges to record Rs 1.78 lakh crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's annual defence production touched an all-time high of Rs 1.78 lakh crore in the financial year 2025-26, the defence ministry said on Wednesday.

The milestone represents a 15.6 per cent growth over the previous fiscal year's output of Rs 1.54 lakh crore and a staggering 110 per cent increase since 2020-21 when the figure was Rs 84,643 crore, it said.

Defence minister Rajnath Singh said the "remarkable rise" in India's defence production in recent years is the result of the collective efforts of the Department of Defence Production and all other stakeholders.

"This upward trajectory is a clear indicator of the country's expanding defence industrial base," he said.

"With sustained policy support, several new initiatives, increased private sector participation, and growing export capabilities, the defence production sector is poised for continued acceleration in the years ahead," he said.

The defence ministry said the rise in the defence production is "staggering" and that it is an 110



Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit reviews the progress of the Tejas LCA Mk1A programme and other indigenous aviation projects, in Bengaluru

Takeaways

- » The milestone represents a 15.6 per cent growth over the previous fiscal year's output of Rs 1.54 lakh crore'
- » This upward trajectory is a clear indicator of the country's expanding defence industrial base, said Rajnath

in 2013-14, it said.

"The Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs) and other PSUs accounted for approximately 76 per cent of total production, while the private sector contributed 24 per cent which is a rise from 22 per cent in 2024-25," the ministry said.

"The share of the private sector is at its all-time high of around Rs 42,000 crore in 2025-26, reflecting its expanding role in the defence ecosystem," it added.

The ministry said the growth in defence production over the years has "tremendously" contributed in achieving the record defence exports of Rs 38,424 crore in 2025-26.

per cent increase since 2020-21 when the figure was Rs 84,643 crore. The indigenous defence production has increased almost four times from Rs 43,746 crore

J&K: NIA seizes assets linked to alleged Pakistan supported terror plot

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday attached two properties belonging to an accused in a Pakistan-backed terror conspiracy case in Jammu and Kashmir's Baramulla district, as part of its ongoing crackdown on terrorism and terror financing in the Union Territory.

Hidden behind quiet names on paper, land ties back to Shaheen Ahmad Lone - named in a case about moving weapons across the Line of Control from Pakistan into Jammu and Kashmir. Authorities say those materials fed attacks in the valley, handed off to fighters linked with groups barred under law: Hizbul Mujahideen and Lashkar-e-Taiba. What was shipped wasn't just gear - it powered violence, backed by supply lines traced through investigations run by the NIA.

That fall, agents uncovered Lone's role funneling money to extremists. By September 2020, NIA had taken him into custody. Prosecutors filed formal accusations the following March. Laws used stretched across multiple sections of the UA(P) Act.

Right now, the court hearing moves forward at the NIA Special Court located in Jammu. While proceedings take place, each detail unfolds under close observation by those involved. This session marks a key phase, though nothing stands concluded yet. So far, everything follows procedure without sudden shifts. The location remains fixed, the record unchanged, and attention stays high.

Carried out under Section 33(1) of the UA(P) Act, the attachment came after directions from the NIA Special Court in Jammu. Though ordered later, it built on earlier legal steps taken at the regional level. Only then did enforcement follow through official channels without delay.

Chh'garh: 3 killed, 2 injured as sand mining dispute turns violent; 4 held

KOREA: A long-standing sand mining business rivalry between two families turned fatal for three men who were brutally attacked by a group of people in Chhattisgarh's Korea district, leading to the arrest of four persons, while others are on the run, officials said on Wednesday.

Two persons were seriously injured in the incident, which occurred in Katgodli village under Sonhat tehsil on Tuesday night, involving a truck, an SUV, and a sedan.

The victims were travelling in two vehicles, includ-

'One of the occupants, Bharat Singh was charred to death at the spot'

ing an SUV and a sedan, when they were allegedly attacked by members of a rival group, a police official said.

As per preliminary investigation, the attackers repeatedly rammed the SUV with a light tipper truck, damaging the vehicle and jamming its doors, preventing the occupants from

escaping. The SUV subsequently caught fire, he said.

Eyewitnesses claimed that some occupants who attempted to break the vehicle's windows and flee were assaulted by the attackers.

One of the occupants, Bharat Singh (aged around 60), was charred to death at the spot, while two others travelling in the SUV suffered severe burn injuries, the official said.

The attackers also targeted the second vehicle and assaulted its two occupants, leaving them critically injured, he said.

PUCL claims Census data altered, calls for review

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Serious concerns have emerged from the People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL) regarding potential data distortion in the current Census House Listing phase. Information gathered on site may be subject to changes under influence, it is suggested.

Pressure reportedly placed upon field staff could shift recorded details toward conformity with state-presented positions. While operations continue, discrepancies raise questions about integrity. Alignment between real conditions and reported figures appears uncertain at this stage.

'Information gathered on site may be subject to changes under influence'

Recently, PUCL released a statement drawing from accounts collected by survey workers across Rajasthan and additional regions.

Officials reportedly directed personnel to alter information related to sanitation, shelter quality, water supply through taps, cooking energy sources, alongside power availability. The group notes these actions cast doubt on the accuracy of

official counts. Hidden behind adjusted figures are lived experiences of those already excluded.

Precision in documentation appears compromised when pressure shapes reporting outcomes. Reality, especially for vulnerable groups, risks distortion under such influence.

Not one detail stands alone when counting people shapes how aid flows, borders form, votes matter - distorting figures strikes at legal entitlements. From Rajasthan came a note dated June 2, signed by the regional census chief, which some interpret as permission masked in procedure to adjust raw survey results.

The civil liberties organisa-

tion also pointed out challenges encountered during data collection - low compensation, dependence on private cell phones, along with demands to fulfil institutional targets.

What stands clear is PUCL calling for an impartial investigation into claims of misconduct. Protection must follow for those field staff who report concerns. I

n place of current oversight, a separate verification system should take shape. Only when census officials openly confirm their process remains free from partisan influence can trust emerge. A truthful account depends on conditions unchanged by pressure.

SEEKS ROADMAP FOR REFORMS

Parl panel flags continuing exam irregularities

NEW DELHI: A Parliamentary committee has expressed concern over continuing examination irregularities despite measures taken by the government, and recommended that the Ministry of Education publish a time-bound roadmap for implementing reforms suggested by a high-level panel.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, headed by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, presented its 381st action taken report on the recommendations contained in the 364th report on Demands for Grants (2025-26) pertaining to the department

Closer Look

» The committee has endorsed Education minister Pradhan's acknowledgement of June 16, 2024, that 'a lot of improvement is needed in the NTA'

» 'The Committee notes the steps taken by the ministry, including the constitution of a high-powered steering committee headed by K Radhakrishnan to monitor implementation of recommendations of HLCE'

of higher education to Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan on Tuesday.

The committee has endorsed Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's acknowledgement of June 16, 2024, that "a lot of improvement is needed in the NTA". It rec-

ommended that the National Testing Agency (NTA) expedite the implementation of the Radhakrishnan Committee's recommendations.

The Parliamentary committee also recommended that the department and the NTA conduct additional widespread

consultations with all stakeholders to adopt a protocol for the "foolproof" administration of nationwide competitive examinations, the report said.

"The Committee notes the steps taken by the ministry, including the constitution of a high-powered steering committee headed by K Radhakrishnan to monitor the implementation of the recommendations of the high-level committee of experts (HLCE).

"However, despite these measures, the paper irregularities are still happening, leading to cancellation of examinations, thereby causing a lot of anxiety among students," the report said.

CISF enhances airport safety amid rising Indian air travel

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), which began its aviation security journey with the takeover of Jaipur Airport in February 2000, has emerged as the backbone of India's civil aviation security network, currently safeguarding 72 airports across the country.

The latest addition to its portfolio is Darbhanga Airport, which came under CISF protection in May 2026.

Later came responsibility for airport safety, after IC-814 was taken in 1999; because of that incident, local control gave way to federal oversight. Under new direction, protection evolved - special units formed, methods refined - not just routines, but smarter ways using tools and constant watch.

Under the oversight of the Ministry of Home Affairs, cooperation unfolds between CISF and the Ministry of Civil Aviation alongside BCAS. Security at airports moves forward through joint effort - not only with carriers but also operational teams managing terminals.

Input arrives regularly from intelligence units while alignment continues with enforcement organisations. Smooth functioning emerges when multiple entities operate in step, despite differing roles. Coordination remains steady even as responsibilities shift across groups involved.

Despite shifting demands, security measures now include ten training centres certified by BCAS, focused on aviation safety. Modern tools like full-body imaging devices, explosive detectors, and unified monitoring setups have been put into use. Alongside these, smoother travel experiences emerge through programs similar to Digi Yatra, reducing physical interaction during movement.

Aravalli range facing existential crisis due to mining, say environmentalists

A group of environmentalists, ecologists and social activists also stated that the destruction of the Aravalli range can accelerate desertification

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Spread across 700 kilometres, the Aravalli range faces an existential crisis due to licensed and illegal mining, and infrastructure projects, a group of environmentalists, ecologists and social activists said in a statement on Wednesday.

They also stated that the destruction of the Aravalli range can accelerate desertification.

This is because the range is a natural barrier against northern desertification, and it protects biodiversity and water recharge.

The group, Aravalli Virasat Jan Abhiyaan, released the statement on the World Day to Combat Desertification and Drought, observed every year on June 17.

Neelam Ahluwalia, co-founder of the group, said, "Experts directly link desertification to the large-scale destruction of the Aravallis by



Key Points

- » he group, Aravalli Virasat Jan Abhiyaan, released the statement on the World Day to Combat Desertification and Drought, observed every year on June 17
- » Kailash Meena, a social activist, noted that due to mining activities, groundwater levels have drastically fallen in the Aravalli region

mining."

Ahluwalia explained that the mining could aggravate vegetation loss, thereby increasing the risk of desertification, "which in turn threatens food and water security of

North West India."

She highlighted that 31 Aravalli hills have completely disappeared in Rajasthan's Alwar district due to mining, according to the findings of a 2018 Supreme

CBI raids 14 sites in Uttar Pradesh over Rs 4 crore fraud

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI/LUCKNOW: On Wednesday, investigations expanded when the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) initiated search operations at fourteen sites spanning Lucknow, Ayodhya, Kushinagar, Pratapgarh, and Amethi within Uttar Pradesh. These actions followed suspicions of misappropriation involving state finances amounting to nearly Rs 4 crore.

On June 8, the CBI opened proceedings after being instructed by the Allahabad High Court's Lucknow division; that direction came nearly a month prior, on May 25, stemming from legal action initiated by Shrawan Kumar Dwivedi. Previously, responsibility rested with regional officers who first documented events at Gauriganj's station - Amethi district - on March 21, 2025. Initiation followed an official report submitted by someone serving in financial oversight within the Basic Education Department.

Reuben Azar, and several other dignitaries were present on the occasion.

During the programme, the Chief Minister inaugurated the Centre of Excellence for Floriculture and Seed Production Technology established by the Horticulture Department in village Munimpur. Set up at a cost of Rs 8.50 crore, this state-of-the-art centre aims to promote floriculture and the production of quality seeds.

The centre will play a significant role in connecting farmers with modern technologies and creating new opportunities in the horticulture sector.

Thereafter, the Chief Minister inaugurated the newly con-

Vadodara: Eight killed, 26 injured as private bus crashes into parked truck



A damaged bus stands at the accident site after it crashed into a truck, in Vadodara, Wednesday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

VADODARA: Eight people were killed -- all but one were passengers -- and 26 others injured after a private luxury bus coming from Rajasthan rammed into a stationary truck on a highway in Gujarat's Vadodara district in the early hours of Wednesday, police said.

The bus driver was among those killed in the crash on the Vadodara-Halol Highway. The accident occurred near Kotambi village on Vadodara city outskirts at around 4 am when the bus, travelling from Rajasthan towards Surat, crashed into the truck parked on the road-

side, officials said.

"Eight people died, while 26 others were injured in the accident. While six of them were killed on the spot, two injured passengers succumbed during treatment later in the day. The bus driver was among those who lost their lives," Vadodara Superintendent of Police Sushil Agrawal told reporters in the evening.

Most of the passengers on board the bus were from adjoining Rajasthan, Agrawal said.

According to police, the truck driver had stopped the vehicle to check tyre pressure when the speeding bus collided with it from the rear side.



EDITORIAL

BATTLE FOR THE SENA

Political parties often survive electoral defeats more easily than they survive internal divisions. Elections come and go, but splits leave lasting scars. The possibility of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs breaking away to form a separate parliamentary group has once again brought Maharashtra's most consequential political schism into focus. Four years after the rebellion led by Eknath Shinde transformed the state's political landscape, Uddhav Thackeray appears to be facing another test of his authority. The significance of the development lies not merely in the numbers involved but in what it says about the continuing struggle for the Shiv Sena's identity and legacy.

The reported move did not emerge overnight. Political observers have spoken of months of quiet discussions, speculation and strategic positioning. More importantly, it comes at a politically symbolic moment. Any shift of MPs around the Shiv Sena's Foundation Day would strengthen Shinde's claim to being the rightful inheritor of the party founded by Bal Thackeray. Since the 2022 split, the contest between the two factions has been fought on multiple fronts—courts, legislatures, election campaigns and public perception. Every elected representative who changes sides becomes part of a larger narrative about legitimacy and momentum. In that sense, the issue extends far beyond parliamentary arithmetic.

For Uddhav Thackeray, the challenge is particularly significant because it raises questions about organisational stability. After the original rebellion, he succeeded in retaining a substantial section of the Sena's traditional support base. Many voters viewed the split sympathetically, seeing him as the wronged party in a struggle for control of the organisation. However, sympathy alone cannot sustain a political movement indefinitely. Parties ultimately depend on strong structures, effective leadership and confidence among their elected representatives. Continued speculation about defections suggests that the process of organisational consolidation remains incomplete.

The episode also exposes the limitations of India's anti-defection framework. The law was intended to discourage political opportunism and ensure stability in elected bodies. Yet experience has repeatedly shown that while individual defections have become more difficult, organised breakaways continue to find legal and political pathways. As a result, the survival of political parties depends less on statutory protections and more on their ability to maintain internal cohesion. The recurring crises within the Shiv Sena illustrate this reality with unusual clarity.

There is, of course, a national dimension to the developments. Should the MPs eventually align with the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance through the Shinde faction, the ruling coalition would gain additional strength in Parliament while simultaneously weakening an opposition ally. The numerical impact may be limited, but politics is often shaped by incremental advantages. Every additional MP contributes to a broader strategy of consolidation. For opposition parties, repeated defections can be as damaging psychologically as they are numerically, creating perceptions of instability that are difficult to counter.

Yet politics is not governed by numbers alone. Leaders have often emerged stronger after periods of adversity. For Uddhav Thackeray, the present challenge offers an opportunity to demonstrate that his political relevance extends beyond appeals to legacy and sentiment. He must reassure party workers, strengthen organisational structures and present a convincing vision for the future. Ultimately, the story is not simply about six MPs changing sides. It is about the continuing battle over what the Shiv Sena represents and who will define its future. The outcome will shape not only Maharashtra's political landscape but also the evolving dynamics of opposition politics in India.



WHO SAID WHAT



Rajdeep Sardesai
@sardesairajdeep

Six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs have reportedly submitted letter to Lok Sabha speaker asking to merge in Shiv Sena (Shinde). NDA tally will now go upto 320 and counting. One rebel MP tells me: 'we were told if you want funds for your constituency, switch!' Operation Lotus 2.0 no longer needs flowers. Just a funding formula. Yeh hai aaj ki rajneeti!

NEXUS OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND A FORMER CIVIL SERVANT

By persuading schools to eliminate plastic tiffins, water bottles, and textbook covers, Pune's Mission City Chakra is demonstrating that waste prevention begins long before garbage reaches a landfill

When Principals Make Policy

Mission City Chakra is showing how simple school-level decisions can reduce plastic waste, protect children's health, and transform sustainability into a community movement

It was an event organised by the Pune City Chapter of Nexus of Good, and I was on a visit to the city. I am so glad that I attended the event, which featured two presentations on some amazing work being done in the region. One such presentation was made by Aditi Deodhar about the manner in which her organisation is attempting to galvanise Pune towards becoming a zero-waste city. An inspiring effort in the true spirit of Nexus of Good.

Mission City Chakra began with a vision of a zero-waste Pune through circular-economy principles and sustainable solutions. As work was initiated on waste management across the city, an important realisation emerged. The garbage seen on roads, in rivers, and at dumping grounds was not the real problem. It was merely a symptom. Waste begins much earlier. It begins with everyday decisions—what we buy, what materials we use, and what products we choose to surround our lives with.

If the waste crisis was truly to be solved, one had to go to the source. One had to address the decisions that create waste before the waste is generated. But there is another reason to act. Waste is not merely an environmental issue; it is also a health issue. And nowhere is this more relevant than in our schools.

The Plastic Around Our Children's Food

Consider the daily routine of a schoolchild. Every morning, food is packed into a tiffin box. Water is filled into a bottle. Textbooks are carried in a school bag. For many children, all three are made of plastic. This may seem normal because it has become common. Yet, when we step back and examine the situation, an important question emerges:

A child enters school at the age of five and graduates around the age of fifteen. For nearly ten years, five or six days every week, they eat food from a plastic container and drink water from a plastic bottle. That amounts to thousands of meals and thousands of refills over the course of childhood.

Research from around the world has shown that plas-



Every school principal is also a policymaker whose decisions can influence entire families

tics can break down into microscopic particles called microplastics. These particles have now been found in our food, drinking water, air, soil, oceans, and even within the human body.

Scientists continue to study their long-term health impacts, but the evidence is increasingly pointing towards concerns related to human health, particularly for growing children. If we already have durable, affordable, and reusable alternatives, should plastic remain the default choice for storing the food and water our children consume every day? Mission City Chakra believed the answer was no.

The Principal as a Policymaker

When people hear the word "policymaker", they often think of governments, ministers, or bureaucrats. Mission City Chakra introduced a different perspective: every school principal is also a policymaker. A principal decides school rules, influences institutional culture, and shapes the behaviour of hundreds or even thousands of students. A single decision taken by a principal can influence not only children but entire families. Recognising this potential, Mission City Chakra launched a simple but powerful appeal to schools:

No Plastic Tiffin.
No Plastic Water Bottle.
No Plastic Textbook Covers.

These three everyday items are present in almost every child's life. Replacing them with durable and affordable alternatives such as steel tiffins, steel water bottles, and reusable non-plastic covers can significantly reduce unnecessary plastic consumption while simultaneously reducing children's daily exposure to plastic.

The idea was not to create another environmental campaign. The idea was to create a preventive health and sustainability policy at the school level.

From Awareness to Action

Through Mission City Chakra, schools across Pune were engaged through awareness programmes, sustainability discussions, and direct interaction with school leadership. The response demonstrated the power of institutional action. To date, 866 schools in Pune city have been onboarded under Mission City Chakra, reaching approximately 3,85,000 students. Out of these, 183 schools have already implemented the appeal for plastic-free tiffins, plastic-free water bottles, and non-plastic textbook covers.

This translates to more than 1,04,000 students who are now part of this sustainability

and health initiative. Importantly, the impact extends far beyond the students themselves. Every school policy reaches households. When a principal adopts such a policy, the message travels from the classroom to the dining table. Parents become participants. Families begin discussing alternatives. Consumption patterns start changing at home. In effect, more than one lakh families have already received and acted upon this message through the leadership of school principals.

Waste Prevention Is Better Than Waste Management

Traditional waste management starts after waste is created. Waste is collected, transported, segregated, processed, recycled, or landfilled. Mission City Chakra focuses on a different question:

What if the waste was never created in the first place?

A steel tiffin box can last for years. A steel water bottle can accompany a child through much of their school journey. Reusable non-plastic textbook covers eliminate the annual cycle of plastic wrapping and disposal. Every plastic item avoided means one less item to collect, transport, recycle, or discard. The result is less plastic waste entering the environment, lower pressure on municipal waste systems,

and reduced chances of plastic leaking into rivers, lakes, and ecosystems. The most sustainable waste management is waste reduction.

A Model Ready for Scale

What has begun in Pune has the potential to become a state-wide and national movement. India has more than 250 million school-going children. Imagine the impact if every school adopted three simple policies:

No Plastic Tiffin.
No Plastic Water Bottle.
No Plastic Textbook Covers.

Unlike large infrastructure projects, these changes require minimal investment. They rely primarily on awareness, leadership, and institutional commitment. State education departments could issue sustainability advisories. School accreditation frameworks could include waste-prevention indicators. Municipal corporations could recognise and reward schools implementing such measures. Most importantly, principals across India could be empowered as sustainability policymakers.

Building a Healthier Future

Environmental challenges often seem overwhelming. But meaningful change rarely begins with massive projects. It begins with small decisions repeated consistently by millions of people. A steel tiffin box may appear insignificant. A steel water bottle may appear ordinary. A non-plastic textbook cover may seem like a small change. Yet, together, they represent something much larger. They represent a conscious decision to protect children's health, reduce unnecessary plastic consumption, and prevent waste at its source.

Mission City Chakra has demonstrated that when principals act as policymakers, schools become powerful centres of change. One principal influences a school. One school influences hundreds of students. Hundreds of students influence hundreds of families. And together, those families influence the future of a city. The journey towards a cleaner and healthier India may begin with a principal's decision and a child's lunch box.

Views expressed are personal

FRONTIER WATCH



DIVYA DHINGRA

THE WRITER IS A RESEARCH SCHOLAR AND AN ALUMNA OF IIT DELHI

Beyond Fences and Frontiers

From fencing vulnerable stretches to deploying smart surveillance, India is increasingly viewing border management as a governance challenge rather than merely a security concern

For years, India's border states have lived with the consequences of decisions made far from the frontier. When infiltration rises, it is the local administration that struggles with verification. When smuggling networks expand, it is the district police that bears the burden. When security vulnerabilities emerge, they are first felt not in New Delhi but in villages and towns closest to the border.

Border districts do not have the luxury of treating infiltration as an occasional headline. For them, it is a lived reality. This is why Amit Shah's recent push on border security deserves to be viewed not merely as a national security initiative but as a governance reform.

Much of India's border debate has traditionally oscillated between alarm and neglect. Illegal infiltration becomes a subject of intense discussion after a security incident or during an election cycle, only to fade from public attention thereafter. Yet for states such as West Bengal, Punjab and Rajasthan, the challenge is far more enduring. It affects law enforcement, welfare delivery and the everyday functioning of government institutions.

West Bengal offers perhaps the most compelling example. Sharing a long and complex border with Bangladesh, the state has historically faced challenges arising from illegal crossings, smuggling networks and porous stretches that were difficult to monitor effectively. The recent transfer of land to the Border Security Force for fencing is therefore significant not only because it strengthens security, but because it improves the state's ability to exercise administrative control



Border management in the 21st century must be proactive rather than reactive

over vulnerable areas that have long remained exposed.

Fencing is often viewed solely through a security lens. Yet its effects are administrative as well. Effective border management makes it easier to prevent document fraud, improve beneficiary verification and ensure that public resources reach their intended recipients. In an age where welfare systems are increasingly digitised and identity-linked, administrative integrity begins with knowing who is legally present in the system.

In Punjab, the border story has changed. The issue is not about who crosses the border but what crosses it. Drones which carry narcotics and contraband have altered the security landscape, often bypassing traditional barriers altogether. In such cases,

stronger fencing is not enough. Real-time intelligence and technological capabilities become just as important.

Amit Shah's Smart Border initiative is an acknowledgement of that changing reality. The project seeks to deploy advanced surveillance systems across India's international borders. More importantly, it reflects an understanding that border management in the 21st century must be proactive rather than reactive. The objective is not merely to intercept unlawful activity but to create a security architecture capable of identifying vulnerabilities before they become a crisis.

Equally noteworthy is Shah's emphasis on what he has described as "territorial security". The phrase captures an important reality. Security challenges do not end once a border

has been crossed. They often present through illegal settlements and systematic exploitation of administrative loopholes, and addressing such challenges requires coordination between border forces, local police and intelligence agencies.

That explains the growing focus on integrated security frameworks and coordinated enforcement. It also explains why Amit Shah has framed illegal infiltration not as a localised issue but as a challenge with implications for governance, welfare systems and social stability.

Seen in this context, the recently constituted high-level committee under a former Supreme Court Justice should be understood as part of a border institutional effort. Its mandate to study demographic changes linked to illegal infiltration is less about political messaging and more about developing an evidence-based understanding of how prolonged infiltration affects governance outcomes in different regions.

The significance of Amit Shah's border security push lies not in any single announcement or enforcement drive. Rather, it lies in recognising that border management is fundamentally a governance challenge. For states that sit on India's frontiers, stronger borders mean stronger institutions, better administrative capacity and greater confidence that public resources and opportunities are reaching those for whom they are intended.

Ultimately, secure borders are not an end in themselves. They are the foundation upon which effective governance rests. For India's border states, that may prove to be the most important dividend of all.

Views expressed are personal

THE DEAL IS DUE TO BE FORMALLY SIGNED IN SWITZERLAND ON FRIDAY

‘Iran will reopen Hormuz, can sell oil freely under deal with US’

DUBAI: Iran will immediately take steps to reopen the Strait of Hormuz once a tentative deal with the US to end the war is signed and will be allowed to sell its oil without restrictions, according to leaked copies of an interim agreement that officials say broadly matches the document.

The accord, due to be signed Friday in Switzerland, also envisions Iran receiving at least \$300 billion to rebuild after the war and says the US would work to end all American and United Nations sanctions imposed on Tehran — if a final agreement addressing Iran's nuclear programme is reached. US President Donald Trump on Wednesday cast some uncertainty on whether the signing would happen as planned. Asked how confident he was that the ceremony would take place, Trump remarked on the unpredictability of deals. "You never know with deals, do you? But you're going to find out pretty soon," he said.

The US and Israel went to



The two sides are to start 60 days of negotiations over a final deal

war on February 28 in part to prevent Iran from ever getting a nuclear weapon, although Trump's goals in the conflict have repeatedly shifted. The interim deal stops the

war before that aim is secured. Instead, it opens a two-month period for nuclear negotiations and appears to offer Iran several benefits up front while extracting little in return. The US agree-

ment to immediately allow Iran to sell its oil freely and the offer to eventually lift all sanctions, for instance, represent major concessions that go beyond the terms of Iran's 2015 nuclear

Highlights

- » The accord lays out that the US would secure at least \$300 billion to rebuild Iran
- » The US agreement to immediately allow Iran to sell its oil freely
- » The deal calls for an immediate end to all fighting in Lebanon between Israel and the Iranian-backed militia Hezbollah

deal with world powers. Trump withdrew America from that pact in his first term, declaring it the "worst deal ever".

The accord likely will draw intense opposition in Washington, and it appears to be a major setback for Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who has come under criticism at home from the media, his opponents and even some allies as details emerge. AGENCIES

G7 focuses on contentious future of AI, US dominance of industry



The G7 includes France, Canada, Germany, Italy, Japan, the US and the UK

AP/PTI

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: Leaders at the Group of Seven summit wrap up three days of talks in the French Alps on Wednesday with discussions on the contentious future of artificial intelligence and US dominance of the industry.

US President Donald Trump and other national leaders are closing the formal talks of the leading industrial nations in the lakeside resort of Evian-les-Bains with a session on the future of artificial intelligence and another on fostering economic growth.

The heads of several leading AI companies will attend the discussions, including OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Google

THE HEADS OF SEVERAL LEADING AI COMPANIES WILL ATTEND THE DISCUSSIONS

DeepMind CEO Demis Hassabis and Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei.

Trump plans to stop outside Paris for a glitzy dinner at the Palace of Versailles before he jets back to Washington on Wednesday.

The G7 leaders spent the bulk of the meetings Tuesday discussing the war between

Russia and Ukraine and a tentative deal to end the Iran war. Trump did not reveal details of the agreement expected to be signed by the United States and Iran on Friday at a resort on Switzerland's Lake Lucerne.

The G7 includes France, Canada, Germany, Italy, Japan, the US and the United Kingdom. Guest nations at this summit include Brazil, Egypt, India, Kenya, South Korea, Qatar, Ukraine and the United Arab Emirates.

The tentative agreement would provide Iran with at least \$300 billion to rebuild after the intense US and Israeli-led bombing campaign, according to leaked copies of the document. AGENCIES

DEPICTS INACCURATE INDIA MAP

US drops 'Indo' from military command name

Key Points

- » The website section where the inaccurate map is placed contains a disclosure that the concerned web page was last updated in March
- » The map in question excludes Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and Aksai Chin from India

Chin from India.

The website section where the inaccurate map is placed contains a disclosure that the concerned web page was last updated in March.

New Delhi maintains that the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of India by virtue of the "complete,

legal and irrevocable accession" of Jammu and Kashmir to India in 1947.

Opposition party Congress has criticised the BJP-led government over the map issue.

Congress' media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra said: "Modi Ji's friends have an uncanny habit of acting against India, India's interests,

and India's friends. The latest example? The US Pacific Command used an incorrect map of India, excluding Jammu & Kashmir and depicting PoK as Pakistani territory."

"One is compelled to ask: Why would any country need adversaries when its PM has thrown the country into such exploitative friendships?" Kherra said.

The Pacific Command operated under the US PACOM banner for over 70 years, standing as the oldest and largest of the United States' unified combatant commands, the Department of Defence said in a statement. It was renamed as the US Indo-Pacific Command in 2018 during US President Donald Trump's first term in office.

"The US Pacific Command ... is back," Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said in a post on X. The US Pacific Command extends from the US West Coast to India's western border. AGENCIES

Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu set to face voter fury over Iran deal

JERUSALEM: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's hopes of clinging to power in an election this autumn have long been shaky, but the interim U.S. deal with Iran has added yet another complication.

U.S. President Donald Trump has opted to end the wars in Iran and Lebanon long before Israel's goals were accomplished, and Netanyahu's boast in March that "we



Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu

are changing the face of the Middle East" looks increasingly empty.

Already facing corruption allegations, domestic political controversies and criticism over security failings in the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack on Israel, he will now face voters' judgement of his handling of the wars and Israel's relationship with the United States, its most important ally.

Netanyahu, 76, confirmed this week he intends to stand again in an election that must be called by October. AGENCIES

EU parl backs law allowing offshore detention centres

Move underlines rise in anti-immigration sentiment across the European Union

BRUSSELS: The European Parliament approved on Wednesday an overhaul of migration policy aimed at ramping up deportations and allowing member states to set up detention centres abroad, in what critics describe as a cruel system that weakens safeguards for asylum seekers.

The move underlines the rise in anti-immigration sentiment across the European Union over the past decade that has broadened popular support for far-right parties.

The text, which requires final formal approval from the 27 EU member governments, marks a sharp hardening of EU migration policy that has taken shape since an influx of over a million refugees and migrants in 2015-16.

"The Return Regulation will provide the necessary tools to make returns more efficient, with faster and more effective procedures," European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said in a letter on

EU countries say they struggle to ensure that rejected asylum seekers and people who overstay their visas leave their territory

Tuesday addressed to member states ahead of a meeting of EU leaders in Brussels.

EU countries say they struggle to ensure that rejected asylum seekers and people who overstay their visas leave their territory.

Critics argue EU migration policy has become too heavily focused on deterrence and deportation, overlooking the root causes of migration including conflict, poverty and political repression. The Commission last month invited Taliban officials to Brussels to discuss deportations of Afghan migrants. AGENCIES

Government of Jammu & Kashmir
Office of the Superintending Engineer PMGSY (JKRRDA) Circle Srinagar
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS
E-NIT NO: 07/SE/PMGSY/S/DB OF 2026-27 dated: - 17-06-2026

The Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Srinagar on behalf of Government of Jammu & Kashmir invites Percentage rate bids in electronic tendering system for construction and maintenance of roads under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana for the following works including their maintenance for five years from the eligible and approved contractors registered with J&K State Govt. CPWD, Railways and other State Governments.

S. No	Name of Work with Package No.	Tendered Cost including GST (Rs in lacs.)				Construction document (Rs. in lacs)	Sanctioned Money (Rs. in lacs)	Completion of construction n of	Tender Call	Date of opening of tenders online (Technical)	Class of contractor.
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	
1	Construction and Maintenance of road from L024-PARIGAM KATRASOO KM 1ST RD 100 TO DHUWOTH " Package No JK18-4038 Sanctioned Length - 1.70Kms carriage way width 3.75Mtr, (Complete stage) under PMGSY IV Batch 1st (2026-27) Block Kulgam PMGSY Division Kulgam Waste Plastic	289.51	23.16	312.67	0.10	6.25	18 Months	2nd	01.07.2026 At 11:00AM	"A" Class in PWD or Equivalent in CPWD/ Railways and other state Governments	
2	Construction and Maintenance of road from L030-Link road) Brariangan to Budwath KM 2nd RD 500 m to Budwath Upper GB" Package No JK01-4038, Sanctioned Length - 1.70Kms carriage way width 3.75Mtr, (Complete stage) under PMGSY IV Batch 1st (2026-27) Block Shangus PMGSY Division Anantnag Waste Plastic	404.60	32.36	436.96	0.10	8.74	18 Months	2nd	01.07.2026 At 11:00 A.M	"A" Class in PWD or Equivalent in CPWD/ Railways and other state Governments	

1. Details released for invitation to bid through procurement: 17.06.2026.
2. The advertisement is available on the website of the Government of Jammu & Kashmir at <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in> and on the website of the Government of Jammu & Kashmir at <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in>.
3. Availability of Bid Documents and mode of submission: The bid documents are available online and offline. The bidder is required to register on the website <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in> and obtain the Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from the authorized Certifying Authorities (CA). Aspiring bidders who have not obtained the DSC should apply for the same immediately. The bid documents are available on the website of the Government of Jammu & Kashmir at <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in>.
4. The bidding documents can be downloaded from the website <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in> from 18.06.2026 (10:00 AM) to 30.06.2026 (4:30 PM).
5. The bids shall be deposited in electronic format on the website <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in> from 26.06.2026 (10:00 AM) to 30.06.2026 (4:30 PM). The bids uploaded on the Web Site up to due date and time will be opened online on 01.07.2026 at 11:00 AM in the presence of the bidders who wish to attend. If the date of opening of the bids as specified happens to be a Govt Holiday, the bids will be opened on the next working day at the same time and venue.
6. The complete bidding process will be online.
7. The advertised amount is inclusive of GST. The bidder shall quote % age (above or below) for the construction component only in the BOQ. However, GST @18% shall be added separately at the time of allotment. All duties, taxes, royalties and other levies payable by the Contractor under the Contract, or for any other cause, shall be included in the rates, prices, and total Bid price submitted by the Bidder.
8. A Pre-bid meeting will be held on 25-06-2026 at 12:00 hrs in the Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Srinagar at Engineering Complex Bund Road Rajbagh Srinagar to clarify the issues and to answer questions on any matter that may be raised at that stage as stated in Clause 9 of instruction to bidders of the Bidding documents. The intending Bidders, before attending the Pre-bid meeting, are advised to visit the site of work and acquaint themselves with the site of conditions. It has been made mandatory for all the intending bidders to participate in the pre-bid meeting on the scheduled date and time.
9. The bidder is required to provide a performance security of Rs. 10 Lakhs in the form of a bank guarantee or a cash deposit to the Government of Jammu & Kashmir. The bidder is required to provide a performance security of Rs. 10 Lakhs in the form of a bank guarantee or a cash deposit to the Government of Jammu & Kashmir.
10. The bidder is required to provide a performance security of Rs. 10 Lakhs in the form of a bank guarantee or a cash deposit to the Government of Jammu & Kashmir.
11. Bidders may bid for any one or more of the works mentioned in the Table above. To qualify for a package of contracts made up of this and other contracts for which bids are invited in this e-NIT, the bidder must demonstrate experience and resources sufficient to meet the aggregate of the qualifying criteria for individual contracts.
12. The Hard Copy of original instruments in respect of affidavits, (cost of tender document, bid security (online mode)) and credit facility must be delivered by participating bidders in the office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Srinagar at Engineering Complex Bund Road Rajbagh Srinagar on a date not later than three working days after the opening of Technical qualification part of the bid either by Registered Post or by hand failing which the bids shall be declared non-responsive.
13. The bidders are advised to upload the required documents/information strictly as per the formats given in Section 3-Qualification Information. The bidder who fails to comply with the said instructions shall be declared as non-responsive.
14. The date and time of opening of Financial Bids shall be notified on Web Site <http://pmgsytenders.gov.in>. This is conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial bids shall be opened accordingly on line on same Web Site at the Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Srinagar, Engineering Complex Bund Road Rajbagh Srinagar.
15. Other details concerning the bidding documents, bid data sheet, Event/they are stated in the e-NIT. The bidders are advised to read the e-NIT carefully and to comply with the instructions therein. The bidders are advised to read the e-NIT carefully and to comply with the instructions therein. The bidders are advised to read the e-NIT carefully and to comply with the instructions therein.
Note: The intending bidders are advised to study the entire bidding document before preparation and submission of their bids. This includes clause 3 (Eligible Bidders), 4 (Qualification of Bidders) of ITB (Instruction to Bidders), Appendix to ITB, Section 3 (Qualification Information), Contract Data to G.C.C. & Section 7 of Bidding Document

No.-SE/PMGSY/S/DB/e-Tendering
Dated: - 06-2026
DIP No:DIP/J-2236/26

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
PMGSY Circle Srinagar

GOVT. OF MAHARASHTRA

Public Works (Project) Division, Pune - 411 001.
Phone No. 020/29985861
Web- www.mahapwd.gov.in & e-mail- projectpune.ec@mahapwd.com
E-TENDER NOTICE No.02 (RFP)FOR 2026-2027

Sealed Online RFP (Request for Proposal) Tenders are Invited By The Executive Engineer, Public Works (Project) Division, Pune - 411 001. (Telephone No. 020/29985869) Invites bids for Given works Consultancy Services RFP (Request for Proposals) Tender Format.

Bids document can be downloaded from website <https://mahatenders.gov.in>. Executive Engineer reserves all rights to accept or reject bids without assigning any reasons. Conditional bids will not be accepted.

The detailed Tender Notice can be available on
1. [Web-www.mahapwd.gov.in](http://www.mahapwd.gov.in) (Only Tender Notice)
2. <https://mahatenders.gov.in> (Details of Tender Notice)

(P. V. Pandit)
Executive Engineer,
Public Work (Project) Division,
Pune 411 001.

Dgipr/2026-27/1171

Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER PMGSY JKRRDA JAMMU
Phone No.: 0191-2470284, Fax No.: 0191-2479335

Subj:- Corrigendum regarding correction in unit of measurement in BOQ & Change of critical dates of bid/extension in e-NIT

Ref:- This office e-NIT No. CEJ/PMGSY/818 of 2026-27 dated 25-05-2026 issued vide endorsement No:- CEJ/PMGSY/4218-4202 dated 25-05-2026.

CORRIGENDUM II

"It is hereby clarified that, in the BOQ pertaining to S. No. 19 of the above-referred e-NIT, the unit of measurement against BOQ Item at Serial No. 31 shall be read as 'Sqm' instead of 'Cum'. Consequently, the critical dates of the Work at S. No. 19 in above-referred e-NIT have been revised as per the details given below:-"

S.No	Particular	Original date	Revised date
1	Closing date of down loading bidding documents.	17-06-2026 (05.00 PM)	20-06-2026 (05.00 PM)
2	Dead line for submission of bids in electronic format on the web site.	17-06-2026 (05.00 PM)	20-06-2026 (05.00 PM)
3	Time and date of opening of received bids on the website.	19-06-2026 (11.00 AM)	23-06-2026 (11.00 AM)

Rest all other terms and conditions will remain same as already advertised.

No.-CEJ/PMGSY/ 6452-6526
Dated:-15-06-2026
DIP No:DIP/J-3880/26

Chief Engineer PMGSY (JKRRDA) Jammu
For and on behalf of The Government of Jammu and Kashmir

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform public in general that Kotak Mahindra bank Ltd has organized an auction in below mention respect of Vehicles. **VEHICLES FOR SALE**

1) VECVL EPRO2114XP
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UNDER HYPOTHECATION WITH M/S KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK IS UNDER SALE IN ITS "AS IS WHERE IS CONDITION" INTERESTED PARTIES CAN GIVE THEIR QUOTATIONS WITH IN 7 DAYS AT BRANCH ADDRESS: KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK 3RD FLOOR, PLOT NO 7, SECTOR 125, NOIDA-201313 OR CONTACT : PUNIT PARASHAR KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK LTD. CONTACT NO. : 8377905498 EMAIL:punit.parashar@kotak.com

SET TO BECOME INDIA'S BIGGEST-EVER PUBLIC ISSUE

NSE files paper for Rs 30,000-cr IPO

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) on Wednesday filed preliminary papers with markets regulator Sebi for its much-awaited IPO, estimated at around Rs 30,000 crore, a share sale that is poised to become the largest public issue in Indian stock market history.

The filing marks a major milestone for NSE, whose listing plans had been stalled for nearly a decade due to regulatory hurdles, including the co-location controversy.

The public issue will be entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of 14.89 crore shares with existing shareholders collectively divesting nearly 6 per cent of the exchange's stake, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP).

Among the top-selling shareholders, State Bank of India will offload up to 2.48 crore shares, followed by MS Strategic (Mauritius) Limited with 1.60 crore shares.

Meanwhile, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), the single largest shareholder



in NSE, holding a 10.72 per cent stake, will not offload any shares.

Other key sellers include Canada Pension Plan Investment Board (1.19 crore shares), Aranda Investments (Mauritius) Pte Ltd (1.12 crore shares), Bank of Baroda (1.10 crore shares), Stock Holding Corporation of India Ltd (1.09 crore shares), General Insurance Corporation of India (1.07 crore shares), The New India Assurance Company (1.05 crore shares), National Insurance Company (0.60 crore shares) and United India Insurance Company (0.60 crore shares).

The State Bank of India (SBI) has a 3.23 per cent stake in the NSE, and its subsidiary, SBI Capital Markets, holds a 4.33 per cent stake in the exchange. Stock Holding Corporation of India owns a 4.44 per cent stake.

According to people familiar with the matter, the IPO size could be around Rs 30,000 crore, implying a market capitalisation of over Rs 5 lakh crore. NSE has around 1.8 lakh shareholders.

This long-awaited public offering will surpass the previous record held by Hyundai Motor India's Rs 27,870 crore issue launched in October 2024.

Jio may file \$4 bn IPO papers

MUMBAI: Billionaire Mukesh Ambani's telecom venture Reliance Jio Infocomm is preparing to move ahead with its long-awaited initial public offering (IPO), potentially setting the stage for India's biggest-ever share sale after months of delay amid volatile market conditions.

Jio could file its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) within days. The filing is expected ahead of Ambani's closely watched annual address to shareholders of Reliance

Industries on Friday, Financial Times reported, citing people familiar with the development. The proposed IPO is expected to raise around \$4 billion, making it the largest public offering in India's corporate history. The listing has been eagerly awaited by investors since Ambani first indicated plans to unlock value in the telecom business. In his address to shareholders in August 2025, Ambani had said that Jio's listing would take place in the first half of 2026. However, the company appears set to miss that timeline following a challenging year.

AGENCIES

ber 2024. The filing comes after NSE's board approved the proposed IPO on February 6 following receipt of Sebi's no-objection certificate (NOC).

NSE had first filed draft offer documents in 2016 to raise around Rs 10,000 crore through an OFS by existing

shareholders. However, Sebi withheld approval amid concerns related to governance lapses and the co-location case.

Since then, the exchange has made multiple representations to the regulator seeking clearance and has undertaken various governance and compliance measures.

AGENCIES

VON DER LEYEN AFTER TALKS WITH PM MODI

'India, EU to sign historic FTA by end of 2026'

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: India and the European Union will sign the ambitious free trade agreement by the end of this year, top EU leader Ursula von der Leyen said on Wednesday after holding talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi that largely focused on boosting two-way economic engagement against the backdrop of a fragile geopolitical environment.

In the meeting, held on the sidelines of the G7 summit in this French commune, the two sides also resolved to step up security and defence cooperation. Besides Von der Leyen, the President of the EU Commission, the meeting was joined by European Council President Antonio Costa.

The leaders stressed the expeditious signing and implementation of the trade deal as it would unlock huge opportunities for trade and investment and contribute towards diversification of supply chains, particularly in the current turbulent geopolitical context, according to an Indian readout.

India and the EU announced the conclusion of the negotiations for the free trade agreement -- billed as the "mother of all deals" -- following the summit meeting between PM Modi and the top



PM Narendra Modi with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President Antonio Costa

PTI

ment and contribute towards diversification of supply chains, particularly in the current turbulent geopolitical context, according to an Indian readout.

India and the EU announced the conclusion of the negotiations for the free trade agreement -- billed as the "mother of all deals" -- following the summit meeting between PM Modi and the top

EU leadership on January 27.

The free trade agreement that will account for almost a quarter of the global GDP will reduce tariffs on 99 per cent of Indian exports to the EU and cut duties on over 97 per cent of the EU's exports to India, according to officials.

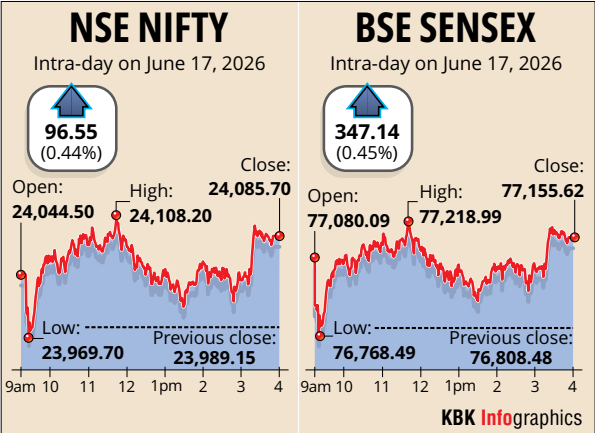
"Since we have concluded the mother of all trade deals, we have been moving fast to

deliver on our commitments. We will sign the Free Trade Agreement with the end of the year. And accelerate work on an investment agreement," Von der Leyen said on social media.

"We will also step up security & defence cooperation. And join forces for better connectivity by advancing IMEC, the India-Middle East-Europe Corridor," she said. Costa also made an identical social media post. India and the EU announced concluding negotiations for the mega trade deal at their summit meeting in January in New Delhi.

The PM said he and the EU leaders discussed how to further deepen economic linkages. "At the start of this year, India was proud to host them for our Republic Day celebrations. This has been a great time for India-EU ties as we have concluded the Free Trade Agreement," he said on social media.

AGENCIES



benchmark, traded at around USD 79.10 per barrel.

In four days, the BSE benchmark has jumped 3,323.07 points, or 4.50 per cent, and the Nifty surged 924.1 points, or 3.98 per cent.

The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 1.20 per cent and SmallCap Select index went up by 0.31 per cent.

Sectorally, Capital Goods surged 2.76 per cent, Industrials (1.83 per cent), PSU Bank (1.80 per cent), Consumer

Durables (1.39 per cent), Power (1.19 per cent) and Metal (1.15 per cent).

Utilities, Auto, Realty were the laggards.

A total of 2,404 stocks advanced while 1,876 declined and 163 remained unchanged on the BSE.

In Asian markets, South Korea's Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended higher, while Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled lower.

FY26: India's exports hit record USD 863 bn

Guj emerged as a major contributor, accounting for \$110 bn in exports

mately USD 441 billion to USD 863 billion over the last decade, led by sectors such as engineering goods, petroleum products, electronics, pharmaceuticals, gems & jewellery, and chemicals. He added that Gujarat has emerged as a major contributor to this growth, accounting for nearly USD 110 billion in exports. Bhadoo said Special Economic Zones will be promoted in the coming years.

"There are sustained efforts to promote new special economic zones in Gujarat and across India. Recently, the government notified an SEZ to be set up by Tata Semiconductor Manufacturing Private Limited in Dholera," he said.

MPST

PM pitches for global framework to boost trade & connectivity

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday pitched for setting up a global framework to boost cooperation on connectivity and trade by combining the strengths of the G7 nations, India and the Global South countries.

The prime minister floated the proposal to set up the International Mobilisation Partnership for Accelerating Connectivity and Trade (IMPACT) while speaking at an outreach session of the G7 summit in this French commune. Modi said the new framework can be modelled on the ambitious IMEC or India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. "Like the vision of IMEC, can we work on connectivity projects with countries in Africa, Latin America and the Pacific Islands?" he asked.

"By combining G7 capital, India's talent and the ownership of Global South countries, we may also consider establishing an International Mobilisation Partnership for Accelerating Connectivity and Trade (IMPACT)," Modi said.

The prime minister was speaking on the session titled 'Reviving a Balanced, Shared and Sustainable Economic Growth for All.' "It is good that the French G7 Presidency has given importance to this topic. The reality today is -- when it comes to growth, the question

He said the new framework can be modelled on the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)

should not be about GDP or trade numbers. The real question is - Growth for whom, with whom and in what direction?"

The IMEC initiative was firming up on the sidelines of the G20 Summit in Delhi in 2023. Billed as a pathbreaking initiative, it envisages a vast road, railroad and shipping networks among Saudi Arabia, India, the United States and Europe with an aim to ensure integration among Asia, the Middle East and the West.

The project has not taken off yet in view of the crisis in the Middle East.

In his remarks, the PM also elaborated on the strengths of the Global South nations. "Today, many societies are becoming ageing societies while India and other countries of the Global South have abundance of young talent, entrepreneurship and skills," he said. "To harness this natural complementarity, called for the creation of a Global Skills Partnership, where we can work together on skill mapping and promoting trusted skilled mobility."

AGENCIES

BSE-listed firms' mcap reclaim \$5-trillion mark

MPST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies regained the USD 5-trillion mark on Wednesday, with investors' wealth rising by Rs 22.78 lakh crore, as equity benchmark indices rallied for the fourth straight session supported by softening crude oil prices following a peace deal between the US and Iran.

In four trading days, the BSE benchmark Sensex has jumped 3,323.07 points, or 4.50 per cent, and the NSE



Nifty surged 924.1 points, or 3.98 per cent.

In four days, investors' wealth surged Rs 22.78 lakh crore taking the market capitalisation (mcap) of BSE-listed firms to Rs 4,75,12,374.27 crore (USD 5.03 trillion).

Domestic airlines' operating profit to 'decline 10-15%' in FY27: Report

MUMBAI: The operating profit of domestic airlines is estimated to decline 10-15 per cent this fiscal due to elevated aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, airspace restrictions and rupee depreciation amid the West Asia conflict, a CRISIL report said on Wednesday.

Rating agency CRISIL also said that the combined impact of higher costs, constrained pricing power and capacity rationalisation is expected to reduce the aggregate operating profit of the airlines to Rs 16,000-17,000 crore this fiscal

from around Rs 19,000 crore in the preceding financial year.

Any respite from lower jet fuel prices, driven by a potential resolution of the conflict in West Asia, will contain further escalation in fuel costs for airlines, it said. However, ongoing fleet expansion will push up lease rentals, and that, coupled with moderating operating profits, could weaken lease serviceability through internal accruals, the report noted, adding that the upshot is expected to be around a 15 per cent increase in rental costs to Rs

27,000-28,000 crore this fiscal.

Jet fuel accounts for nearly 40 per cent of an airline's operating costs under normal circumstances and can go to as much as 60 per cent of total operating expenditure during periods of extreme fuel price volatility. Such fluctuations can significantly impact airline operations, route planning and fare stability.

The West Asia conflict has led to a sharp average increase of over 50 per cent in global ATF prices versus the pre-conflict levels.

AGENCIES

India-UK trade deal to come into effect on July 15, says PM

EVIAN-LES-BAINS: The India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement will enter into force on July 15 and it will significantly boost bilateral trade and investment ties, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Wednesday.

The prime minister said the trade deal will unlock numerous opportunities for Indian farmers, workers, startups and innovators.

"A historic milestone for India-UK relations. Delighted to note that the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement will enter into force on 15th July 2026," Modi said on social media.

"This agreement will significantly boost our bilateral trade and investment. It will also unlock numerous opportunities for Indian farmers, workers, MSMEs, startups and innovators and contribute meaningfully to the realisation of Viksit Bharat 2047," he said.

The prime minister said the trade pact will bring significant momentum to the economic ties between India and the UK.

AGENCIES

Report: 'India's strategic oil reserves cover only 9-10 days of crude imports'

Countries like Japan & S Korea maintain reserves sufficient for over 200 days

NEW DELHI: India's current strategic petroleum reserves are equivalent to just about 9-10 days of the country's net crude imports, far below other major import-dependent countries, a new report revealed on Wednesday.

The report released by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) said other countries that rely heavily on crude imports -- such as Japan and South Korea -- maintain reserves sufficient for over 200 days.

The report, 'How Secure is India's Energy Future? Assessing Accessibility, Reliability, and Affordability, also noted that over 85 per cent of India's crude oil imports come from just six countries, including Russia and key West Asian suppliers, limiting flexibility supply shocks.

Hemant Mallick, fellow at the CEEW, said, "Disruptions in crude oil, LNG, LPG, coal, or key shipping routes can quickly affect cooking costs, transport fuel prices, fertiliser subsidies, industrial competi-



tiveness, and inflation."

For gas, India imports nearly half its supply as LNG but has no dedicated strategic gas storage facilities, leaving fertiliser plants and city gas networks exposed, the report said.

It also highlighted that the country's coal security risks are increasingly influenced by its continued dependence on imported coking coal -- particularly from Australia -- for steelmaking, and exposure to Indonesian export policies for non-coking coal imports.

On the domestic side, declining coal quality and rising production costs signal a narrowing cost advantage for coal power over firm renewable power, said the report.

It argued that clean energy can reduce India's exposure to continuously imported fossil fuels. However, the report said that clean energy can create a different kind of strategic dependence: on critical minerals, technologies, and industrial inputs.

This dependence must be managed through domestic

manufacturing, supply-chain diversification, recycling, and strategic international partnerships, according to the report.

Mallik said, "India's next phase of energy security must move beyond securing fossil fuels to a clear transition plan: optimising gas system utilisation, avoiding further refinery expansion, accelerating viable EV adoption, electrifying industry, reconfiguring refineries for lower gasoline demand, and building resilient green technology supply chains."

AGENCIES

INSIGHT

- » The report was released by Council on Energy, Environment and Water
- » It said that other countries that rely heavily on crude imports -- such as Japan and South Korea -- maintain reserves sufficient for over 200 days
- » The report also noted that over 85% of India's crude oil imports come from just six countries, limiting flexibility supply shocks

Gold price tumbles Rs 4,800 to Rs 1.54/10g, silver drops Rs 5,300

NEW DELHI: Gold prices plunged by Rs 4,800 to Rs 1.54 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Wednesday, while silver dropped by Rs 5,300, as traders stayed away from precious metals amid a strong rupee and weak global trends. According to the All India Sarafa Association, the yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated Rs 4,800 to Rs 1,54,400 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes). It had closed at Rs 1,59,200 per 10 grams in the previous session.

Silver also weakened sharply, falling by Rs 5,300 to Rs 2,55,400 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had settled at Rs 2,60,700 per kg on Tuesday.

Analysts said domestic demand remained weak for the second straight day as investors chased higher returns amid firm equity markets.

Gold prices declined on Wednesday as investors took a cautious approach ahead of several important US economic events, including the US Federal Reserve's monetary policy decision, Saumil Gandhi,



Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

In the international markets, spot gold slipped marginally to trade at USD 4,327.54 per ounce, while silver fell 0.18 per cent at USD 69.89 per ounce. "Spot gold is consolidating ahead of the US Federal Open Market Committee's monetary policy decision due later in the day," Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

Meanwhile, market participants are also tracking developments ahead of the scheduled US-Iran meeting on Friday.

"Any progress toward a formal agreement may reduce geopolitical uncertainty, while setbacks could revive demand for the precious metals," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said.

AGENCIES

He confirmed their marriage during an interview with 'Esquire' for a new cover story



He was asked whether he had to reassure family members about the AI photos

TOM HOLLAND CONFIRMS MARRIAGE TO ZENDAYA

Hollywood actor Tom Holland confirmed his marriage to 'Spider-Man' co-star Zendaya. Speculation over whether the 'Spider-Man' co-stars had officially tied the knot has been swirling since January, when Zendaya's stylist Law Roach said on the Golden Globes red carpet that their wedding 'already happened' and was 'very true'.

Roach's comments sent social media into a frenzy and sparked a wave of AI-generated images purporting to show Zendaya in a wedding dress at the alleged ceremony. Holland confirmed their marriage during an interview with 'Esquire' for a new cover story. The 30-year-old actor told the outlet that his grandmother saw the photos and thought she hadn't been invited to the wedding.

When asked whether he had to reassure family members about the AI photos, Holland replied: "No, because they were all there."

Asked for a further comment, Holland simply replied, "That's all you'll get on that."

Zendaya, 29, didn't open up about the marriage, but during her press tour earlier this year for 'The Drama', the actress addressed the fake photos on 'Jimmy Kimmel Live'.

The actress revealed that she has been approached by people complimenting her on wedding pictures she had never taken. "They're AI. They're not real," she said, adding that several people in her personal life were also fooled and upset they had not received an invitation.

During the interview with 'Esquire', Holland praised Zendaya as a partner. "I found my person. She's my best friend and I'm the happiest I ever have been when I'm with her, but I also have never felt so supported and safe, ever. Period," the actor said.

"Our business can present very stressful situations and it's really nice to have a bedrock of a relationship that will stand the test of time," he added.

Holland and Zendaya have appeared together in three 'Spider-Man' films, with a fourth, 'Brand New Day'.

Anya Taylor-Joy joins 'The Hunt for Gollum'

The actress will essay the role of Seren, a Sindar Elf of the Woodland Realm

Hollywood actress Anya Taylor-Joy is set to feature in 'The Lord Of The Rings: The Hunt for Gollum'.

The actress will essay the role of Seren, a Sindar Elf of the Woodland Realm, who is described as 'a trusted and lethal agent of King Thranduil', according to the entertainment news outlet 'Variety'.



The film is set between 'The Hobbit' trilogy and 'The Lord of the Rings' trilogy

Taylor-Joy will join the previously announced cast comprising Andy Serkis, Ian McKellen and Elijah Wood. It is directed by Serkis.

The film is set between 'The Hobbit' trilogy and 'The Lord of the Rings' trilogy. The story follows Aragorn and Gandalf

as they search for Gollum to learn more about the origins of Bilbo's mysterious ring.

Peter Jackson is set to produce alongside Fran Walsh and Philippa Boyens. 'The Lord of the Rings: The Hunt for Gollum' is slated for release worldwide in December 2027.

'You don't need to speak to yearn'

Matthæw Broome and Asha Banks star in Prime Video's 'Your Fault: London'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

After winning over romance fans with the first film, Nick and Noah are back and this time, they are no longer just exchanging glances across the room. 'Your Fault: London', based on Mercedes Ron's bestselling 'Culpables' trilogy, picks up a year into their relationship as the pair navigate love, family expectations and everything that comes with



trying to make their relationship work.

For Matthæw Broome and Asha Banks, the lead pair of Prime Video's 'Your Fault: London', that shift meant play-

ing two characters who know each other far better than they did the first time around. When Asha pointed out that they had barely spoken in the first film, Matthæw jokingly said, "You don't need to speak to yearn!"

Speaking about this next stage of Nick and Noah's relationship, Matthæw shared, "It was super exciting because obviously they are a year into their relationship by this point and you are totally different people together. They know

each other so well."

Banks explained that returning to the sequel made her realise just how little their characters Nick and Noah had actually spoken to each other in the first film. "The first film was so much of them getting to know each other and like the looks across the rooms and not actually that much of us speaking. I feel like we came back to the second film, we're like, 'Damn, we've never spoken. We've got to speak to each other!'"

Sport

The GOAT meets greatness again

Messi ties World Cup goals record with a hat-trick as Argentina top Algeria

KANSAS CITY: Lionel Messi used the front of his white-and-blue, sweat-soaked jersey to wipe the tears from his eyes, a flood of emotions cracking his usually calm, confident demeanor after he gave Argentina an early lead in its World Cup opener against Algeria.

Then he scored again. And again.

Suddenly, any questions about Messi's hamstring injury, or whether he could help Argentina become the third team to win consecutive World Cups — even as his 39th birthday approaches next week — had been answered. With a brilliant hat trick in a 3-0 win over Les Fenecs, Messi moved into a tie with Germany's Miroslav Klose for the career scoring record at the men's World Cup.

"My tears after the first goal? I've had some tough days. It wasn't related to football. And those feelings were because of that," Messi said afterward, without elaborating. "I thank my teammates, the coaching staff and the delegation for helping me."

Messi scored that emotional



Argentina's Lionel Messi celebrates after scoring the opening goal

AP

first goal in the opening minutes on a nifty feed from Inter Miami teammate Rodrigo De Paul, the second off an opportunistic rebound early in the second half, and the third on a crisp strike moments before

subbing out to a standing ovation from a crowd of 69,045 tilted heavily toward the three-time World Cup champions.

"At a loss for words about Leo. What can I say?" Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said.

38

At 38 years and 357 days, Messi the oldest player ever to score three goals in a World Cup match

"He's incredible."

Messi has 16 goals in his record six World Cup appearances overall, and it seems inevitable that Klose's record will fall in the coming weeks. The hat trick was the 61st of Messi's career, his 11th while playing in his national team colors and his first in the World Cup.

It also was the fifth straight World Cup game in which Messi has scored.

"It makes me very happy to have lived through everything that came my way. What I'm living through now is the cherry on top," Messi said.

AGENCIES

Haaland bags double on debut

FOXBOROUGH: Norway will go as far in this World Cup as Erling Haaland takes them. In his tournament debut, he showed he's more than up for that challenge.

Haaland scored two goals, including one off a defensive blunder, on Tuesday to propel Norway to a 4-1 victory over Iraq in Group I. The Manchester City striker's 56th and 57th international goals came in Norway's first appearance in the tournament since reaching the knockout round at the 1998 World Cup in France — two years before Haaland was born.

Haaland said he will do his best to meet the expectations he created with this performance.

AGENCIES

EAST RUTHERFORD: After a flat first half, Kylian Mbappé got France back in tune.

Mbappé scored twice to move past Pelé with 14 World Cup goals, celebrating by mimicking a flutist as he had promised, and Les Bleus beat Senegal 3-1 Tuesday in their World Cup opener. "He could have scored four or five goals, OK, theoretically, but we're happy with two goals," France coach Didier Deschamps said.

Mbappé had 14 touches in the scoreless first half, the fewest of any player, then put France ahead in the 66th minute. He burst past Senegal captain Kalidou Koulibaly, turned onto a diagonal pass from Michael Olise and slid the ball past goalkeeper Édouard Mendy from just outside the 6-yard box.

In a segment with Mbappé taped May 20 and aired Friday by U.S. broadcaster Fox, award-winning actor and television host James Corden suggested the 27-year-old star striker celebrate his next World Cup goal by imitating a flute player. "I'll do it for you first game,"



Kylian Mbappé celebrates scoring a goal against Senegal

AP

58

Mbappé has surpassed Olivier Giroud (57) to become France's all-time leading goalscorer with 58 goals

Mbappé said. Mbappé ran toward a corner, brought both hands to his lips and air-tooted for a few seconds. "If he wants to miss the first half again and score two goals in the second half in another match, that's OK with me," Deschamps said.

Bradley Barcola doubled the lead in the 82nd, two minutes after entering, and Ibrahim Mbaye cut the deficit in the stoppage time. Mbappé scored just 68 seconds later on a spectacular right-footed shot from 30 yards.

AGENCIES

Shafali-Smriti charge floors Dutch

LEEDS: Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma sizzled with the bat as India coasted to an emphatic 95-run win over the Netherlands in their Women's T20 World Cup match here on Wednesday.

The Indian opening duo of Mandhana (74 off 47 balls) and Shafali (55 off 38 balls) slayed a hapless Netherlands attack to fire India to 209/5, their highest total in the tournament history.

The pair shared a 115-run stand off 70 balls after Netherlands put the opposition in to bat. The Netherlands were never in the run chase despite promising knocks from skipper Babette de Leede (28 off 27 balls) and Sterre Kallis (18 off 13 balls) before being bundled out for 114 in 17.3 overs.

From India's point of view, the biggest scare came when

The Indian opening duo of Mandhana (74 off 47 balls) and Shafali (55 off 38 balls) slayed a hapless Netherlands

off-spinner Shreyanka Patil was stretched off the field after twisting her ankle while fielding off her very first ball of the evening.

India next face a much tougher opponent in South Africa in Manchester on June 21.

On her World Cup debut, pacer Nandani Sharma had a productive outing.

She had opener Heather Siegers caught at cover for a

memorable first wicket in her first ICC game.

Deepthi Sharma, star with the ball against Pakistan, stuck in her first over having Phebe Molkenboer caught at mid-off.

Netherlands' de Leede and Kallis played a few crisp strokes before departing in quick succession.

It was a procession thereafter as India completed the formalities. The wily Shree Charani was too good for the opposition's middle and lower-order and was also on a hat-trick in the 17th over. She was all over Netherlands after trapping Robine Rijke in her third over. Kallis played down the wrong line to be castled by Shafali Verma while de Leede was stumped after missing a short ball from Nandani on the charge.

AGENCIES

MEXICO CITY: Mexico and South Korea will put their perfect starts on the line when they meet on Thursday in Guadalajara, with the winners taking a major step toward securing top spot in World Cup Group A.

Co-hosts Mexico opened the tournament with a 2-0 win over South Africa but coach Javier Aguirre faces key selection decisions after defender Cesar Montes was sent off in a chaotic second half that produced three red cards.

Montes will miss the clash through suspension, forcing a reshuffle at the back, with captain Edson Alvarez among the options to fill the vacancy in central defence while Israel Reyes could also be moved inside from right back.

Aguirre could also hand a starting role to Gilberto Mora

after the teenager impressed off the bench in the opener. At 17, Mora is the youngest player at the tournament and energised Mexico's attack during his World Cup debut, increasing calls for a place in the starting lineup.

South Korea also began with a victory, overcoming the Czech Republic 2-1 thanks to a late winner from striker Oh Hyeon-gyu. Coach Hong Myung-bo's options have expanded since that match, with midfielders Bae Jun-ho and Kim Tae-hyeon nearing returns from injuries that disrupted their preparations for the tournament. Hong must also decide how best to use captain Son Heung-min, whose influence has waned since his move to Major League Soccer side LAFC last year.

AGENCIES



AROUND THE WORLD

» Gujarat Police tightens security measures ahead of Re-NEET

» India, Slovakia deepen ties in research and AI after PM Modi meets Slovak PM Robert Fico

» Jamia Millia Islamia concludes placement session for MA Social Work & HR Management

» India among top 3 destinations for AI talent even as global skilled migration falls 12%: BCG report

BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHO IS THE FATHER OF THE INDIAN IT INDUSTRY?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our June 11 edition question: **Ramdeo Misra**

Correct answers were sent by: **Kushal Mishra, Ranjan Kundu, Sucharita Mitra**

NEWS & VIEWS

IIM Lucknow has signed a MoU with Indian Railways Institute of Transport Management, Lucknow, for collaboration in executive education, research, and management development initiatives for Indian Railways officers. The collaboration aims to enhance leadership capabilities, managerial excellence, and research-driven innovation within the Indian Railways ecosystem.

IIT Roorkee has launched an executive programme in AI for E-Commerce & Quick Commerce in collaboration with TeamLease EdTech. The six-month programme is designed to help working professionals build applied capabilities in artificial intelligence for one of India's fastest-evolving digital business sectors.

ADMISSION ALERT

IM Lucknow opens dual-degree in AI & Business Analytics



Last date to apply is July 3

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IIM Lucknow has announced the launch of its Bachelor of Science (BS) in Artificial Intelligence & Business Analytics programme, designed specifically for young higher secondary graduates. Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had launched the course.

Applications are invited from Indian candidates who have successfully completed 10+2 or equivalent examinations in 2025 or 2026 with Physics, Chemistry and Mathematics as main subjects, qualified JEE Advanced.

A unique feature of this programme is the opportunity for students to transition to the Tech-MBA programme (scheduled to commence in 2027-28) after completing the third year of the BS programme. This

KNOW THE DETAILS

» Application close date: **JULY 3, 2026**

» First list announcement: **JULY 10, 2026**

» Reporting and registration: **AUGUST 17, 2026**

» Session starts: **AUGUST 18, 2026**

pathway will enable eligible students to convert their studies into an integrated dual-degree programme at IIM Lucknow.

Candidates will be selected based on their academic performance and JEE Advanced qualifying score. It is notable that a relaxation of 5% marks shall be applicable for candidates belonging to SC/ST categories as per the Government of India norms.

IN INTERNET AGE, WHY COVER UP MOHENJODARO'S 'DANCING GIRL', ASK GEN Z

NCERT decides to restore the original image of the Harappan-era bronze figurine

URJA SAHA

Imagine opening the history textbook you grew up reading about the famous bronze sculpture known as the Dancing Girl of Mohenjodaro, only to find it 'covered up' to make it age-appropriate in a Class 9 NCERT art history textbook. As a parent, the obvious concern would be whether history and art are being presented to students as they are, or whether the past is being modified to suit contemporary notions of propriety. This 4,500-year-old bronze figurine, depicting a girl standing with one hand on her hip, is one of the most recognisable artefacts of the Indus Valley Civilisation.

However, after the alteration prompted widespread criticism from historians, educators and artists, NCERT officials announced that the original image has been restored in the digital version of the book and that future print editions will also carry the unedited photograph of the sculpture



In today's digital age, children have access to a wide variety of content through the internet, social media and OTT platforms. An ancient sculpture in a history textbook is unlikely to be the most concerning thing they encounter

— Aparupa Roy, student, Presidency University, Kolkata



revisions to school textbooks and syllabus. Changes ranging from reducing sections on Mughal history and dropping references to the demolition of the Babri Masjid have repeatedly put the institution under scrutiny. The altered image of the Dancing Girl has now sparked a broader debate over whether shielding children from a 4,500-year-old artefact makes sense in a world where nudity is only a click away on the internet. Although the original image has been restored in the digital

edition, the discussion continues, particularly among Gen Z students. Sreemanti Samaddar, a Master's student at St. Xavier's University, Kolkata, said, "The sudden decision to make an important historical artefact of our civilisation appear more modest is absurd and, in fact, counterproductive to learning. The Dancing Girl provides valuable information about the culture of the Harappan Civilisation, including how people dressed and the role of women in that society. Covering the

torso negates much of that context." Apart from stating that the alteration was intended to make educational material more "age-appropriate" and sensitive to cultural sentiments, NCERT did not provide a detailed explanation for why the change was considered necessary. Discovered in 1926, the Dancing Girl remains one of the most recognisable symbols of the Harappan Civilisation. The figurine's bare torso is not unusual in the context of ancient art. Across many civilisations, including those of the Indus Valley, Ancient Egypt, Greece and Rome, nudity often carried cultural, religious or artistic significance and was not necessarily associated with sexuality.

Today's generation is growing up in a digital ecosystem where access to smartphones and the internet begins at a young age. As a result, children are exposed to everything from educational documentaries and social media trends to explicit

material. Streaming platforms have also transformed the entertainment landscape. Web series across various OTT platforms frequently feature nudity, intimate scenes and mature themes. Despite age ratings and parental controls, such content remains easily accessible to many young viewers. Aparupa Roy, a Master's student at Presidency University, Kolkata, disagrees with the decision to cover the figurine's torso. "As a history student, I believe historical artefacts should be presented in their original form and understood within their historical and cultural context. Altering them can affect how we engage with the past," she said. She added, "I do not think it is particularly necessary. In today's digital age, children have access to a wide variety of content through the internet, social media and OTT platforms. An ancient sculpture in a history textbook is unlikely to be the most concerning thing they encounter."

The debate has exposed what many see as a contradiction. At a time when children navigate an increasingly uncensored digital world, an ancient bronze figurine has become the focus of a new moral boundary. Meanwhile, a CBSE school teacher, speaking on condition of anonymity, said, "Today, we cannot control children's digital addiction. They have access to almost anything on their smartphones. If NCERT's intention was to make the image 'age-appropriate', then the education system should focus on regulating children's access to social media, as countries such as Australia have attempted to do. Changing history will ultimately change how future generations understand the past."

Trending COURSES

HYDERABAD GETS IIM RANCHI'S EXECUTIVE COURSE IN PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IIM Ranchi announced its partnership with Masai to introduce an executive programme in Product Management at IIM Ranchi's Hyderabad campus. The 12-week, fully offline weekend programme is scheduled to commence on July 18, 2026, and is designed to equip aspiring product managers, engineers, designers, students and early-career professionals with the frameworks, tools, and practical experience required to operate in product roles.

Delivered across 72 total hours, the programme comprises 60 hours of faculty-led sessions by IIM Ranchi and 12 hours of mentor masterclasses led by industry practitioners. It features bi-weekly sessions with five or

KNOW THE DETAILS

» Start date: **JULY 18, 2026**

» Duration: **12 WEEKS**

» Mode: **OFFLINE**

» Eligibility: **CLASS 12 PASS AND ABOVE**

more industry leaders, in-person capstone project reviews, and a final group capstone presentation defended live before a panel of IIM Ranchi faculty and industry practitioners.

Upon successful completion of the programme, participants will receive a certification from IIM Ranchi. Learners will also receive a project completion letter from Masai for the capstone project undertaken during the programme.

IITS EXPAND ADMISSIONS BEYOND ACADEMICS

Students excelling in sports, fine arts and Olympiads can now secure IIT admission

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Of course, you need to be the best among the best to secure your place at the IITs but then, these prestigious Indian institutes have introduced alternative admission pathways for undergraduate admissions in 2026, creating opportunities for students who have demonstrated exceptional achievements in sports, arts and culture and science Olympiads.



For students with notable accomplishments in the fields of fine arts and culture, IIT Madras and IIT Mandi have launched the Fine Arts and Culture Excellence (FACE) scheme. Candidates seeking admission through FACE must also have cleared JEE (Advanced) 2026. Meanwhile, the Science Olympiad Excellence (SCOPE) scheme will be implemented by IIT Kharagpur, IIT Madras and IIT Mandi. The programme is designed for students with

outstanding performances in recognised science Olympiads. Unlike SEA and FACE, candidates applying through SCOPE are not required to appear for JEE (Advanced).

Under the Sports Excellence Admission (SEA) scheme, IIT Indore, IIT Kharagpur, IIT Madras, IIT Mandi and IIT Roorkee will offer seats to eligible candidates. Applicants must have qualified JEE (Advanced) 2026 to be considered under this category.

BLACKBOARD

Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath has announced a 50 percent concession in fares on the State Road Transport Corporation buses for candidates appearing in NEET 2026, scheduled on June 21. The CM stated that approximately 3.5 lakh candidates will appear for the examination across 59 districts of Uttar Pradesh. To facilitate their travel, candidates will be allowed to avail a 50 percent concession on UPSRTC bus fares upon presenting their NEET admit cards.

IIT Madras has released the world's most detailed 3D Atlas of human brainstem, through its high throughput brain imaging and computing platform that transforms whole human brains into 3D cell-resolution atlases.

Researchers from the Ceramic Engineering Department at NIT Rourkela have developed a unique method to remove dye pollutants from industrial wastewater. This low-cost method addresses a critical environmental challenge of industrial waste contaminating natural water reservoirs.

Oscar-winner Cate Blanchett to teach Contemporary Theatre at Oxford

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Oscar-winning actress Cate Blanchett has been appointed Visiting Professor of Contemporary Theatre at St Catherine's College, University of Oxford, for the 2026-27 academic year.

The two-time Academy Award-winning 'The Aviator' actor joins a distinguished group of artists who have held the prestigious role since its inception in 1990. Former visiting professors include Sir Ian McKellen, Dame Diana Rigg, and Dame Myra Syl.

Reflecting on the appointment, Blanchett said that art has the power to transcend borders and expand human imagination. She noted that engaging with and examining art helps challenge perceptions of reality, while her years of creative practice have enabled her to transform emotions into ideas and discover new paths to understanding, according to the University of Oxford.

St. Xavier's University, Kolkata hosts int'l meet on cryptocurrency & fintech

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The Faculty of Commerce and Management, St. Xavier's University, Kolkata, in collaboration with Kolkata Bidhannagar Society for Academic Advancement, successfully organised the International Conference 2026 on the theme "Decentralized Finance, Cryptocurrency and Fintech: Enroute to Viksit Bharat @2047" in hybrid mode at the university campus recently.

The conference brought together academicians, researchers, industry experts, research scholars and students to deliberate on some of the most contemporary issues in finance and technology. The major themes included decentralized finance, cryptocurrency, blockchain technology, fintech for MSME and rural credit, digital financial inclusion, digital transformation in banking and finance, sustainable finance, ESG, green fintech, and the application of artificial intelligence and machine learning



The main conference received an overwhelming response, with 168 research papers submitted from across India

in financial markets.

Delivering the inaugural address, Rev Dr. John Felix Raj, S.J., Vice-Chancellor of St Xavier's University, Kolkata, observed, "Technology must serve people, finance must support inclusion, innovation must promote development, and growth must be rooted in ethics and human dignity."

As a precursor to the main conference, pre-conference plenary sessions were organized on June 12, 2026, through the online platform. The opening talk was delivered by Prof. Charalampos Stasinakis, Professor of Finance, Adam Smith Business School, University of Glasgow.

This was followed by a panel discussion featuring Dr Manish Jha, Assistant Professor, J Mack Robinson College of Business, Georgia State University; Dr Parthajit Kayal, Associate Professor (Finance Area), Madras School of Economics and Dr Shivam Agarwal, Assistant Professor, Maynooth University School of Business, Ireland. The session was moderated by Dr. Anupam Mitra, Professor and Dean, Faculty of Commerce and Management, St. Xavier's University, Kolkata.

The main conference received an overwhelming response, with 168 research papers submitted from across India. After a rigorous screening process, 85 papers were selected, out of which 70 papers were finally registered for presentation. The technical sessions were conducted in both online and offline formats, with 35 presentations in each mode. A total of 20 distinguished chairpersons and co-chairpersons evaluated the sessions and offered valuable academic guidance to the presenters.